

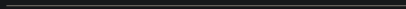


The Key Teachings of
JONATHAN EDWARDS



*For with thee is the fountain of
life: in thy light shall we see light.*

PSALM 36:9



OCHORUS

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Published by Ochorus.

This book is an independent work of exposition, summary and appreciation. All descriptions of Edwards's teaching are the present author's own summaries. Where his sermons and treatises are named, they are named for the reader's further study. Edwards's own writings are in the public domain and are freely available; readers are warmly encouraged to go to them directly.

Unless otherwise indicated, all Scripture quotations are taken from the Authorised (King James) Version, the version Edwards himself preached from.

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Introduction

For with thee is the fountain of life: in thy light shall we see light.

PSALM 36:9

Most people who know the name Jonathan Edwards know one thing about him, and the one thing is misleading.

They know that he preached a sermon about sinners dangling like spiders over a fire. It appears in school anthologies as a specimen of Puritan severity, and it has fixed his reputation for two centuries as a grim man who frightened people for a living.

The sermon is real. He did preach it, at Enfield in July 1741, and we shall come to it. But it is one sermon out of roughly twelve hundred that survive, and it is thoroughly unrepresentative of the rest. The man who preached it also wrote that heaven is a world of love, that God's purpose in creating anything at all was the overflow of His own fullness, and that the difference between a true Christian and a false one is finally a matter of what the soul finds beautiful. He was, in the plainest terms, a theologian of joy who happened once to write something unforgettable about hell.

Why he still matters

Edwards has a strange standing. He is widely agreed to be the most powerful mind the American church has produced, and he is very little read. His treatises are difficult; his sentences are long; his categories belong to the eighteenth century. Most believers who admire him have got him at second hand.

That is a pity, because his central concern is not eighteenth-century at all. He spent his life on a single question, and it is the question the church in every age is least able to answer honestly: *how do you tell the difference between a person who has been changed by God and a person who has merely been stirred?*

He asked it because he had to. He stood at the centre of two great awakenings, watched thousands profess conversion, watched a proportion of them fall away, and refused to draw either of the easy conclusions — that the whole thing was delusion, or that every emotional response was the Spirit of God. He insisted on a third possibility that requires far more work: that God was genuinely at work, that counterfeit was genuinely present, and that the two could be distinguished.

Any church that has ever run a crusade, counted decisions, or wondered what became of last year's converts is standing where Edwards stood.

How this book is arranged

Eighteen short chapters set out the teaching for which Edwards is chiefly remembered, beginning where he began — with God — and moving outward through sin, salvation, the affections, revival, love, and finally prayer and the hope of what God intends to do in history.

Each chapter ends in the same two places: a set of application points and a prayer. This is deliberate, and Edwards would have approved. He held with great firmness that knowledge which never reaches practice is not saving knowledge at all. The last and longest sign in his *Religious Affections* is Christian practice — how a man actually lives — and he ranked it above every inward experience a person might report. A chapter of this book that is read and admired but not obeyed has, by its own argument, failed.

Read one chapter a day, or one a week. Stop at the application points. Pray the prayer, or better, pray your own.

Throughout, his own sermons and treatises are named, so the reader may follow any thread back to its source. A short guide to his works is provided at the end. Edwards's writings are out of copyright and widely available at no cost, which means that unlike most great theologians he can be read entire by anyone with an internet connection and some patience.

One more thing must be said at the outset, and it is better said plainly.

This is not a book of hero-worship. Jonathan Edwards owned slaves.

He purchased a girl named Venus in Newport in 1731, when she was about fourteen. Over the following years his household included others — Leah, Titus, Joseph, Sue, Rose. He opposed the Atlantic slave trade and wrote against it, he baptised black believers and received them into full membership of his church when other ministers would not, and he recorded in his notebooks that master and servant have one Maker who made them alike with the same nature. And he defended the institution itself in a draft letter, and he died without freeing anyone.

There is no way to soften this, and it should not be softened. It was not a blind spot of an age that knew no better; men in his own colony were arguing against slavery in his lifetime, and he answered them. The people who worked in his house made possible the study that produced the books we still read. That fact belongs in any honest account of him.

Why then read him at all? For the same reason we read David, who arranged a murder, and Peter, who denied his Lord, and Paul, who held

the coats. The Scriptures themselves record the failures of the men God used, and they do it without embarrassment and without excusing anything. God has never had any material to work with but sinners, and He has never pretended otherwise.

There is also a grim irony that Edwards himself would have understood. Within a generation, his own son and his closest theological heir, Samuel Hopkins, became leading opponents of slavery — and they argued their case directly from his theology, insisting they were only carrying his own principles where he had failed to carry them. His doctrine of true virtue, of benevolence extended to all being, turned out to contain the refutation of his own practice.

That is precisely what he taught us to expect. No teaching was more central to him than that the human heart is deceitful beyond our capacity to detect, that we are most blind where we most benefit, and that even a converted man may harbour what he has never examined. A book presenting Edwards as a spotless saint would be contradicting the very doctrine it was written to commend.

So the counsel of this book is the counsel of Scripture: *Prove all things; hold fast that which is good* (1 Thessalonians 5:21). Weigh every chapter against the Word of God. Where Edwards is faithful to Scripture — and on the glory of God, the necessity of the new birth, the testing of religious experience and the beauty of holiness, he is faithful indeed — receive it gladly and act upon it. Where he was wrong, and he was, learn from that too. It is one of the more useful lessons he has to teach.

A final word about the reader this book assumes.

Edwards wrote for an English-speaking colonial congregation of farmers and tradesmen in a river valley in Massachusetts. He is now read across the world — in Korea, in Brazil, in Nigeria, in China — by Christians whose circumstances share nothing with his. The reason is not that his setting travels well. It plainly does not. It is that he dealt almost entirely with what does not vary: what God is like, what the human heart is like, and how a person may know whether the grace of God has actually touched him.

Those questions are already waiting wherever this book is opened, in whatever language it is carried.

A Life Spent for the Glory of God

*Whom have I in heaven but thee? and there is none upon earth that I
desire beside thee.*

PSALM 73:25

A house full of daughters. Jonathan Edwards was born on the fifth of October, 1703, in East Windsor, Connecticut, a frontier parish beside the Connecticut River. He was the fifth of eleven children and the only son; his ten sisters were all unusually tall, and their father was said to joke that he had sixty feet of daughters.

His father, Timothy Edwards, was the parish minister, a Harvard man who supplemented a modest salary by farming and by tutoring boys for college. His mother, Esther, was the daughter of Solomon Stoddard, the formidable minister of Northampton, thirty-five miles upriver — a man so dominant in the Connecticut Valley that he was known as the Pope of the region. Between father and grandfather, the boy was surrounded by ministry from birth.

He was extraordinarily quick. As a child he wrote observations on the flying spiders of the New England woods, with a precision that would not embarrass a naturalist. He entered the Collegiate School — soon to be Yale — in 1716, not yet thirteen years old, and graduated at the head of his class in 1720. He stayed two further years in New Haven studying divinity.

A new sense of things. The intellect came early. The religion took longer, and he was honest about why.

By his own later account in the *Personal Narrative*, he had been religious from boyhood — he built a booth in a swamp to pray in, he had seasons of great fervour — and none of it had touched the thing that needed touching. What he could not accept was the sovereignty of God. The doctrine that God chooses whom He will save appeared to him horrible. He fought it for years.

Then, sometime in 1721, reading a verse he had read a hundred times before — *Now unto the King eternal, immortal, invisible, the only wise God, be honour and glory for ever and ever* (1 Timothy 1:17) — something opened. He described a sense of the glory of the divine being diffusing itself through his soul, a kind of sweetness altogether new, and quite unlike anything he had experienced in religion before.

What is significant is what changed. The doctrine he had hated did

not become easier to accept; it became beautiful. He found himself delighting in the very thing that had offended him. This experience became the seed of nearly all his later theology: the conviction that conversion is not the mind being persuaded but the heart being given a new taste, a new sense, so that what was repellent becomes lovely.

Around this time he began his *Diary* and his seventy *Resolutions* — a young man's programme for a life wholly ordered towards God, reviewed weekly, and shot through with an urgency about time that never left him.

Northampton. After a brief pastorate in New York and two years as a tutor at Yale, he was called in 1726 to assist his grandfather at Northampton. In July 1727 he married Sarah Pierpont, whom he had first noticed at thirteen and described in a famous scrap of writing as a young woman who walked about singing, beloved of that Great Being who made the world. The marriage was, by every account, unusually happy. They had eleven children.

Solomon Stoddard died in 1729 and Edwards inherited the largest and most influential pulpit outside Boston. He kept a punishing schedule — thirteen hours a day in the study by some accounts — and preached to a congregation that had grown accustomed to revivals and to being told they were the finest church in the valley.

In 1731 he was invited to preach in Boston, and chose to tell the assembled ministers that God is most glorified in the total dependence of man upon Him. It made his name.

Then, in the winter of 1734 and into 1735, something happened in Northampton that neither he nor anyone else had arranged. Following a series of sermons on justification by faith alone, the town was seized. Conversions ran into the hundreds; the character of the place visibly altered. Edwards wrote it up carefully and without exaggeration, and *A Faithful Narrative of the Surprising Work of God* was published in London in 1737. It made him famous across the Atlantic, and it supplied the template by which a generation would recognise revival.

The Great Awakening. The larger wave came at the end of the decade. George Whitefield preached at Northampton in October 1740 — Edwards is said to have wept through the sermon — and the colonies caught fire.

On the eighth of July 1741, at Enfield, Edwards preached *Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God*. Accounts describe the congregation crying out before he had finished. He read it, as he read most of his sermons, in a level voice from a manuscript held close to his eyes.

But the awakening also produced disorder — shrieking, visions, itinerants denouncing settled ministers, and confident claims to direct rev-

elation. The churches divided between those who declared the whole movement a work of God and those who declared it a delirium. Edwards took the harder path, and it cost him friends on both sides. In *The Distinguishing Marks of a Work of the Spirit of God* (1741) and *Some Thoughts Concerning the Present Revival* (1742) he argued that a genuine work of God may be accompanied by human excess without ceasing to be genuine, and that the way to judge is not by the noise but by the fruit.

The mature statement came in 1746. *A Treatise Concerning Religious Affections* is his masterpiece, and it is a hard book, because it takes away every comfortable test a person might apply to himself and replaces them with ones that cannot be faked.

Dismissal. His grandfather had admitted to the Lord's Table anyone of upright life, whether or not they professed conversion. Edwards came to believe this was wrong, and said so.

The controversy consumed two years and destroyed his ministry. On the twenty-second of June, 1750, the congregation voted to dismiss him, by something like two hundred and thirty votes to twenty-three. He was forty-six, with a large family and no income.

His farewell sermon is remarkably free of bitterness. He told them he would meet them again at the judgment seat, and left it there.

Stockbridge, and the end. In 1751 he took the only position available: a frontier settlement at Stockbridge, with a handful of English families and a mission to the Mahican and Mohawk people. He learned to preach through an interpreter, in short plain sermons, and defended the mission against the settlers who were defrauding it.

It should have been an exile. It became the most productive period of his life. In seven years at the edge of the wilderness, in a house crowded with children and interrupted by war, he wrote *Freedom of the Will* (1754), *The Great Christian Doctrine of Original Sin Defended*, *The Nature of True Virtue* and *The End for Which God Created the World*.

In 1757 the College of New Jersey — later Princeton — invited him to be its president, following the death of his son-in-law. He protested that he was unfit, awkward in company, and better suited to a study. He went anyway.

He arrived in February 1758. Smallpox was in the town, and he was inoculated, which was then a genuine risk. The inoculation went wrong. He died on the twenty-second of March, 1758, aged fifty-four, having been president for about five weeks.

He was conscious near the end, and left a message for his absent wife about the uncommon union between them and his hope that it would continue for ever. To those around the bed he said that they should

trust in God, and then they need not fear.

Sarah died six months later. On hearing of his death she wrote that God had made her adore His goodness — that He had given them her husband for so long, and that she and her children were left to God.

The End for Which God Created the World

For of him, and through him, and to him, are all things: to whom be glory for ever. Amen.

ROMANS 11:36

Everything in Jonathan Edwards begins here, and nothing in him can be understood without it.

In the last years of his life, in a crowded house on the Massachusetts frontier, he wrote a dissertation asking a question most people never think to ask. Not *how* did God make the world, nor *when*, but *why*. What was God after? What did He intend to accomplish by there being anything at all?

An answer we find uncomfortable

Edwards answered that God's ultimate end in creating the world was the glory of God — His own fullness known, communicated, esteemed and enjoyed.

That answer has always troubled people, and it troubles modern readers most of all. It sounds like vanity. We do not admire human beings who arrange everything for their own praise, and we instinctively resist a God who appears to do the same.

Edwards took the objection seriously, and his reply is one of the most bracing arguments in Christian theology. It runs like this.

For any being to value something above what is most valuable would be a falsehood — an error about reality. If God is in fact the highest good, the source and standard of every excellence, then for God to esteem anything else more highly than Himself would not be humility. It would be a lie. It would be God preferring the lesser to the greater, which is precisely what we call sin when we do it.

So God's regard for His own glory is not self-obsession. It is simply God seeing accurately.

I am the Lord: that is my name: and my glory will I not give to another.

ISAIAH 42:8

Why this is good news and not bad

But Edwards pressed further, and this is where the doctrine turns from intimidating to glorious.

Suppose God is the highest good. Then the best possible thing that could happen to a creature is to receive God — to know Him, see Him,

love Him and enjoy Him. There is no superior gift available anywhere in the universe, because there is nothing superior to God.

Which means that when God acts to display His own glory, He is not competing with our happiness. He is securing it. The two are the same act.

Thou wilt shew me the path of life: in thy presence is fulness of joy; at thy right hand there are pleasures for evermore.

PSALM 16:11

A God who sought our happiness *instead* of His glory would have to offer us something less than Himself, and would therefore be offering us something less than the best. Only a God who is thoroughly committed to His own glory can give His creatures what they most need, because what they most need is Him.

Edwards described the whole arrangement as an emanation and a returning — the fullness of God flowing out into the creation, and then flowing back to Him in the knowledge, love and joy of creatures who have received it. The universe is not a machine God built. It is an overflow.

Where Scripture puts the accent

He built the case not on philosophy but on the sheer accumulation of biblical statements, and the accumulation is impressive once you begin to look.

Even every one that is called by my name: for I have created him for my glory, I have formed him; yea, I have made him.

ISAIAH 43:7

For mine own sake, even for mine own sake, will I do it ...and I will not give my glory unto another.

ISAIAH 48:11

Election is *to the praise of the glory of his grace* (Ephesians 1:6). Creation is *by him, and for him* (Colossians 1:16). Redemption issues in a doxology; providence issues in a doxology; the last book of the Bible is one long doxology. Even eating and drinking are brought under the same end: *whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God* (1 Corinthians 10:31).

Edwards's point was that this is not one theme among many in Scripture. It is the theme under all the others, and once a reader sees it he cannot stop seeing it.

What it does to a life

The practical consequence is a reordering of the whole self, and it is more searching than it first appears.

Most of us, if we are honest, hold a version of Christianity in which God is extremely useful. He forgives, comforts, guides, provides and finally saves. All true — and all of it arranged with ourselves at the centre and God in orbit around our needs.

Edwards inverts the diagram. God is not the means to our flourishing; God is our flourishing. Salvation is not primarily rescue from hell but restoration to the one Object for which we were made, and hell is dreadful chiefly because it is exclusion from that Object.

This is why he could write, without any sense of strain, that the redeemed person's happiness and God's glory are not two competing goods that must be balanced. They are one good, seen from two sides.

If this is true, then the question to put to any activity, any ambition, any Sunday morning, is not *did it work?* nor even *did it help people?* but *did God appear great in it?*

That question, asked seriously for a week, will dismantle a good deal.

Two senses of glory

Edwards distinguished carefully between two things the word *glory* can mean, and the distinction removes most of the difficulty people have with this doctrine.

There is God's **internal glory** — the fullness of excellence He possesses in Himself, entirely apart from any creature. This never increases. God was not lonely, incomplete or unfulfilled before the world existed, and creation added nothing whatever to Him. The Father, Son and Spirit had loved one another in perfect sufficiency from eternity.

And now, O Father, glorify thou me with thine own self with the glory which I had with thee before the world was.

JOHN 17:5

Then there is God's **external** or declarative glory — that same fullness shining out, being known, esteemed and enjoyed by creatures who did not exist before. This is what increases, and this is what God is after.

The image Edwards reached for was the sun. Light streams out from it in every direction, illuminating everything it touches. The sun loses nothing by shining; the light is simply the sun's own nature going out. So the creation is not something God needed. It is His fullness overflowing.

And then — this is the part he found most beautiful — the light returns. The creatures who receive it know, love and rejoice in the God who gave it, and the stream flows back to its source. Edwards described the whole arrangement as an emanation and a remanation: outward, and home again.

This answers the charge of divine vanity more completely than any

argument about God's rights. A vain person needs the admiration of others; his emptiness is filled by their regard. God has no emptiness. When He seeks His glory among creatures He is not obtaining something He lacks — He is giving something they lack, namely Himself, and their giving it back to Him in worship is the completion of the gift rather than a payment for it.

For who hath known the mind of the Lord? or who hath been his counsellor? Or who hath first given to him, and it shall be recompensed unto him again?

ROMANS 11:34–35

Paul asks those questions immediately before the doxology that heads this chapter, and the sequence is Edwards's whole argument in miniature. Nobody has given God anything. Therefore *of him, and through him, and to him, are all things* — and therefore, to him be glory.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask of one ordinary task tomorrow — a meeting, a meal, a piece of work — how it could be done so that God appears great in it. Then do it that way.
2. Examine your praying. What proportion asks God to serve your purposes, and what proportion asks that He be glorified whatever it costs you?
3. Read Ephesians 1 and mark every occurrence of *glory* and *praise*. Notice what the whole chapter is driving at.
4. Name one thing you want badly. Ask honestly whether you want it more than you want God, and tell Him the answer.
5. Memorise Psalm 73:25 and use it as a test of the heart when your desires run away with you.

A PRAYER

Lord God, I have made myself the centre of a universe You built for Yourself, and I have called it faith.

Forgive me for wanting Your gifts more than I want You, and for resenting a glory that is the very thing I was made to enjoy.

Teach me that You are not competing with my happiness — that You are my happiness, and that in seeking Your own honour You are giving me the best thing there is.

Let me want what You want. Be glorified in me today, whether or not I find it comfortable. Amen.

Absolute Dependence

*That no flesh should glory in his presence ...He that glorieth, let him
glory in the Lord.*

1 CORINTHIANS 1:29, 31

In July 1731, a young minister from a country parish was invited to preach the public lecture in Boston before the assembled clergy of New England. It was the most prestigious pulpit available to him, and he was twenty-seven years old.

He chose to tell them that they contributed nothing.

The sermon was published as *God Glorified in the Work of Redemption, by the Greatness of Man's Dependence upon Him, in the Whole of It*. It was Edwards's first appearance in print, and it announced the theme he would spend the rest of his life developing.

The three prepositions

His structure came from the text itself, and it is worth following closely, because it is not merely tidy — it is exhaustive.

The redeemed have all their good *of* God. He is the first cause, the fountain from which everything proceeds. Nothing we possess originated with us.

For who maketh thee to differ from another? and what hast thou that thou didst not receive? now if thou didst receive it, why dost thou glory, as if thou hadst not received it?

1 CORINTHIANS 4:7

The redeemed have all their good *through* God. He is not only the source but the means. Salvation does not come to us by some channel God set up and then left running; it comes through the Son who purchased it and the Spirit who applies it. God does not merely supply the materials of our salvation; He is the medium of it at every point.

And the redeemed have all their good *in* God. This is the part most readily forgotten. God does not give us a happiness that is separable from Himself, some blessing we could carry away and enjoy at a distance. The good He gives is Himself. Heaven is not a reward located near God; heaven is God.

Of Him, through Him, in Him. Edwards's conclusion was blunt: at no point in the entire transaction does the creature have anything to contribute, and therefore at no point does the creature have anything to boast about.

Grace does not reduce dependence — it deepens it

Here Edwards made an observation that overturns a common assumption.

We tend to think of grace as a kind of assistance — God supplying what we lack so that we can then manage. On that view, the more grace we receive, the less dependent we become, rather as a child needs less help as he grows.

Edwards argued the reverse. The redeemed are more dependent on God than unfallen Adam was, not less. Adam depended on God for his existence and his faculties. The redeemed sinner depends on God for those things and also for his righteousness, which is not his own; for his faith, which is a gift; for his perseverance, which is kept by another; and for his final glory, which is wholly of grace.

Redemption therefore magnifies dependence. That, in Edwards's view, is exactly why God arranged salvation this way. The design was not merely to rescue sinners but to rescue them in a manner that made the rescuer's glory unmistakable.

Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to his mercy he saved us.

TITUS 3:5

The abolition of comparison

The pastoral consequence is enormous, and it is one of the most freeing things in Edwards.

If everything I have was given, then comparison becomes meaningless. I cannot be superior to another believer on the basis of gifts I did not generate, any more than a man can be proud of the size of an inheritance he did nothing to earn. Paul's question — *who maketh thee to differ?* — is designed to end the conversation before it begins.

This cuts in both directions, and the second is the one we notice less. Comparison downward produces pride; comparison upward produces envy and despair. Both rest on the same error — the assumption that what we have is ours. Remove the assumption and both collapse together.

For without me ye can do nothing.

JOHN 15:5

Edwards took *nothing* at full strength. Not a little. Not less than we might. Nothing.

There is a test buried in this doctrine, and it is uncomfortable.

A man who truly believes he contributes nothing will not be devastated when he is overlooked, because he was never trading on his own account. He will not be inflated when he is praised, because he knows

where the goods came from. His equilibrium under both flattery and neglect is the most reliable public evidence that the doctrine has got past his intellect and into his bones.

Prayer as the confession of dependence

If the doctrine of this chapter is true, then prayer is not principally a technique for obtaining things. It is the posture in which a creature acknowledges what he actually is.

Edwards made this connection repeatedly, and it explains something otherwise puzzling. If God knows our needs before we ask, and intends to supply them, why ask at all?

The answer is that God is not merely giving us things. He is drawing us into a relationship in which we know where everything comes from. A gift received without asking can be enjoyed without reference to the giver; a gift asked for and granted cannot. Prayer is how God arranges that His provision shall also be His self-revelation.

Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you.

MATTHEW 7:7

There is a diagnostic in this, and it is uncomfortable. A prayerless Christian is not merely neglecting a duty. He is making a statement about his own self-sufficiency, whatever his theology says. We pray in proportion to our conscious need, which is why prayer collapses in prosperity and revives in crisis — and why crisis is so often a mercy.

Edwards observed that the same principle governs how God distributes His blessings over time. He gives daily rather than in bulk, as He gave manna in the wilderness, so that dependence is renewed each morning rather than settled once. We would greatly prefer a lump sum. He gives us a day at a time, and calls it our daily bread.

Give us this day our daily bread.

MATTHEW 6:11

This also reframes what we should be asking for. If our highest good is God Himself, then the most important prayers are not for circumstances but for Him — for more of His presence, a clearer sight of Christ, a heart that wants Him. Edwards noticed that such prayers are the ones we make least often, and the only ones we can be certain are according to His will.

If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children: how much more shall your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to them that ask him?

LUKE 11:13

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. List three things you are quietly proud of. Trace each one back to where it came from, honestly, and see whether anything is left to boast in.
2. Notice this week when you compare yourself with another believer. Each time, answer Paul's question: who made you to differ?
3. Watch your reaction to being overlooked. Do not suppress it — examine it. What does it reveal about what you thought was yours?
4. Thank God specifically for one ability you have always assumed was simply your own.
5. In prayer, ask not only for God's help but for God Himself. Notice whether that is a strange request for you.

A PRAYER

Father, I have received everything and behaved as though I had earned something. You are the fountain of all my good, the way by which it reaches me, and the good itself. There is nothing in my hands that You did not put there.

Deliver me from comparison — from the pride that looks down and the envy that looks up. Both are unbelief about where my life came from.

Make me content to be a receiver. And when I am overlooked, let me be steady, because I was never living on my own credit. Amen.

The Sovereignty of God

But our God is in the heavens: he hath done whatsoever he hath pleased.

PSALM 115:3

Edwards did not arrive at the sovereignty of God as an inherited opinion. He arrived at it after years of resisting it, and the record of that resistance is one of the most valuable things he left us.

A doctrine he hated

In the *Personal Narrative* he describes his younger self's objection with startling candour. The teaching that God chooses whom He will save and passes by others appeared to him horrible. He could not make it fit with anything he wanted to believe about God, and he argued against it in his own mind for a long time.

Then something changed, and he was careful to describe the change accurately. He did not say that he found a knockdown argument. He said that the doctrine came to appear to him exceedingly pleasant, bright and sweet — that he came to delight in the absolute sovereignty of God.

That sequence is important, and it recurs throughout his theology. The resolution was not intellectual capitulation. It was a change in what he found beautiful. He began to want a God like that.

Any reader wrestling with these doctrines should note the pattern. Argument has its place, and Edwards was a formidable arguer. But he did not believe anyone was ever finally reconciled to the sovereignty of God by being out-reasoned. Something has to happen to the taste.

What Scripture claims

The claim itself is not obscure. It is stated repeatedly and without qualification.

And all the inhabitants of the earth are reputed as nothing: and he doeth according to his will in the army of heaven, and among the inhabitants of the earth: and none can stay his hand, or say unto him, What doest thou?

DANIEL 4:35

For he saith to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I will have mercy ... So then it is not of him that willeth, nor of him that runneth, but of God that sheweth mercy.

ROMANS 9:15–16

Edwards preached on these texts directly, notably in *God's Sovereignty in the Salvation of Men*. His handling of the standard

objection is characteristically severe and characteristically clarifying.

The objection is that this is unfair. Edwards's answer is that the objection misunderstands what is owed. Justice would give every sinner condemnation; nobody receives worse than justice. Mercy, by definition, is not owed to anyone — the moment it is owed it has stopped being mercy and become wages. God wrongs no one by giving some what none deserve.

Nay but, O man, who art thou that repliest against God? Shall the thing formed say to him that formed it, Why hast thou made me thus?

ROMANS 9:20

He was aware this does not remove the difficulty from the heart. He did not pretend it did. What he insisted upon was that the difficulty is not an injustice in God but an offence to our sense of entitlement — and that our sense of entitlement is itself part of what needs saving.

Why it is a pastoral doctrine

It would be a mistake to file this under abstract theology. For Edwards it was intensely practical, and in two directions.

It kills despair. If salvation depended on the sinner's capacity to generate faith, then the hardened, the addicted, the long-resistant and the intellectually proud would be beyond hope, because they cannot. But if God is sovereign in salvation, no one is beyond reach. Edwards prayed for the most unlikely people in his parish with real expectation, precisely because the outcome did not depend on them.

And it kills presumption. If God's mercy is free, it cannot be commanded, scheduled or taken for granted. The man who assumes he can repent at a convenient time has misunderstood what repentance is and who grants it.

Seek ye the Lord while he may be found, call ye upon him while he is near.

ISAIAH 55:6

One caution, which Edwards's own practice supplies better than any argument.

Nobody preached God's sovereignty more insistently, and nobody pleaded with sinners more urgently. He saw no tension whatever between the two, and he would have regarded a man who used divine sovereignty as a reason not to evangelise as having failed to understand it. The same Scripture that declares God's absolute freedom in mercy commands us without qualification to call everyone.

Whosoever will, let him take the water of life freely.

REVELATION 22:17

Hold both. Edwards did, all his life, and he never showed the slightest anxiety about it.

Sovereignty in providence

Edwards did not confine this doctrine to the question of who is saved. He applied it to everything that happens, and it was in the ordinary disasters of his own life that he had to prove whether he believed it.

Scripture's boldest statements on the subject concern the worst event in history. Peter tells the Jerusalem crowd that they took Jesus and crucified Him — genuinely guilty, genuinely responsible — and in the same breath that this happened by the determinate counsel and foreknowledge of God (Acts 2:23). The church at prayer says the same thing more explicitly still.

For of a truth against thy holy child Jesus ...both Herod, and Pontius Pilate, with the Gentiles, and the people of Israel, were gathered together, for to do whatsoever thy hand and thy counsel determined before to be done.

ACTS 4:27–28

The murder of the Son of God was the freely chosen wickedness of specific men, and it was the settled plan of God for the salvation of the world. Scripture asserts both without embarrassment, and Edwards took that as the pattern for every lesser instance.

But as for you, ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good, to bring to pass, as it is this day, to save much people alive.

GENESIS 50:20

Joseph does not say his brothers meant one thing and it happened to work out. He says God meant it — the same act, two intentions, one wicked and one good.

Edwards had occasion to apply this. He was dismissed at forty-six from the most influential pulpit in the region, by his own congregation, after twenty-three years, with ten children still at home and no income. His letters from that period show a man genuinely wounded and genuinely settled. He went to a frontier village, and there wrote the four books on which his reputation now chiefly rests. Had he remained at Northampton, with its committees and its constant demands, it is unlikely he would have written any of them.

He did not know that at the time. Nobody does.

And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to his purpose.

ROMANS 8:28

That verse is not a promise that events will be pleasant, nor that we shall be told the reason. It is a promise that there is one — and that

the God who governs the crucifixion of His Son is not likely to have lost control of our smaller catastrophes.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Identify which part of God's sovereignty you resist. Say it plainly to God rather than pretending agreement you do not feel.
2. Ask not to be argued into this doctrine but to be given a taste for it. That is the prayer Edwards's own experience suggests.
3. Name one person you have written off as beyond conversion. Begin praying for them again this week on the ground that the outcome does not rest on them.
4. Where you have been presuming on a future opportunity to get right with God, stop presuming. Act now.
5. Refuse the false choice. Pray as though everything depends on God, and speak to people as though the command to call them is absolute — because both are true.

A PRAYER

Lord, You do as You please in heaven and on earth, and there are days when I find that hard rather than comforting.

I will not pretend. Where I resist Your sovereignty, I confess it to You instead of arguing with You.

Do for me what You did for Your servant: not merely convince my mind, but change my taste, until the truth I found threatening becomes the truth I find sweetest.

And let this doctrine make me bolder, not idler — hopeful for the hardest people I know, and urgent with them, because mercy is Yours to give and You have told me to call them. Amen.

A Divine and Supernatural Light

Blessed art thou, Simon Barjona: for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven.

MATTHEW 16:17

In 1734, before the revival that would make him famous, Edwards preached a sermon at Northampton whose title states its whole argument: *A Divine and Supernatural Light, Immediately Imparted to the Soul by the Spirit of God, Shown to be both a Scriptural and Rational Doctrine*.

It is the hinge of his theology of conversion, and it answers a question that troubles thoughtful believers everywhere. How can two people hear the same sermon, read the same verse, receive the same information — and one be transformed while the other is merely informed?

What the light is not

Edwards was careful to fence the doctrine before building it, because he knew where enthusiasts would take it.

This light is not new revelation. It does not add doctrines to Scripture, supply information not contained there, or grant impressions that carry the authority of the Word. Edwards was severe about that, and grew more severe as the awakening produced men claiming direct messages from heaven.

Nor is it a vision, a voice, a feeling of excitement, or a sudden rush of emotion. Nor is it merely being deeply moved by a sermon — an experience available to anyone with a working imagination and a good preacher.

What is it, then? A real sense of the divine excellency of the things already revealed in Scripture. Not new content. New perception of old content.

Knowing about, and knowing

His illustration is the one everybody remembers, and it is perfect.

There is a difference, he said, between knowing that honey is sweet and tasting its sweetness. A man may have read every treatise on honey ever written. He may be able to describe its chemistry, its colour, its use in cookery, and give a lecture that would satisfy an examiner. And if he has never had honey on his tongue, there is something he does not know — something the lecture cannot supply and the taste conveys instantly.

O taste and see that the Lord is good.

PSALM 34:8

Edwards called this the *sense of the heart*, and distinguished it sharply from what he called notional understanding. Notional understanding grasps the proposition. The sense of the heart apprehends the loveliness of what the proposition describes.

A person may hold, correctly and sincerely, that God is holy, that Christ died for sinners, that grace is free. He may defend these against objection. And he may never once have seen them as beautiful. When he does — when the excellency of the thing lands on him — everything changes, and he cannot afterwards explain why he did not see it before.

For God, who commanded the light to shine out of darkness, hath shined in our hearts, to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:6

Note the language: *light*. The same God who spoke at creation speaks again, and the result is not additional information but illumination.

Why it must be given

It follows that no one can produce this in himself or in anyone else.

But the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God: for they are foolishness unto him: neither can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned.

1 CORINTHIANS 2:14

The difficulty is not that the natural man lacks intelligence. Edwards was emphatic on this, and it matters: a very clever person may be entirely blind here, and a very simple one may see clearly. The faculty required is not mental capacity. It is a spiritual taste that must be created.

This is why Peter's confession drew the response it did. He had said what others could have said. What the Lord commended was the source: *flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee*.

Edwards would not let his hearers conclude that they should therefore sit passively and wait. God ordinarily gives this light through the means He has appointed — the reading and preaching of His Word. The farmer cannot make the rain, and he plants anyway.

The test of it

How does a person know whether he has this light or is deceiving himself?

Edwards gave a test that is impossible to counterfeit: the light produces love for the thing seen. A man who has genuinely perceived the excellency of God does not merely assent to God's holiness; he finds it lovely, and he wants it in himself. The perception and the affection arrive together, because seeing beauty and loving it are one act.

If a person's religion consists of correct opinions that leave the heart unmoved and the life unaltered, he has notions, not light.

There is enormous comfort in this doctrine for those who feel their understanding is small.

You are not required to be brilliant. Some of the people Edwards observed most transformed in the Northampton revival were servants, children and the uneducated, who grasped the loveliness of Christ while learned men debated at a distance. The light is not distributed according to intellect. It is given.

Which means the right response to a passage of Scripture that has never moved you is not to study harder — though study — but to ask.

The means God uses

If this light is given and cannot be produced, does a believer simply wait?

Edwards answered no, and his reasoning matters, because his doctrine has often been distorted into passivity.

God ordinarily gives this light through means, and the chief means is His Word — read, preached, discussed and thought about. The Spirit does not usually illuminate a mind that has been given nothing to illuminate. Revelation is not an alternative to knowing the content of Scripture; it is the content becoming luminous.

So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

ROMANS 10:17

He put considerable weight on this in his preaching practice. His sermons are densely doctrinal, and deliberately so. He believed the preacher's task was to set the truth before the mind as clearly and fully as possible — and then to press it upon the affections — while knowing perfectly well that neither the clarity nor the pressing could produce the light.

The farmer's position is exactly analogous. He cannot make it rain. He ploughs anyway, because rain falls on ploughed and unploughed ground alike and only one of them yields a harvest.

I have planted, Apollos watered; but God gave the increase.

1 CORINTHIANS 3:6

This also explains why doctrine matters so much to a theologian of

the affections, which surprises some readers. You cannot find beautiful what you do not know. A person with a thin, vague, sentimental idea of God has very little for the Spirit to make lovely. The richer and more accurate a believer's grasp of who God is and what He has done, the more surface there is for the light to strike.

So Edwards's counsel to anyone who finds Scripture dull is twofold, and both halves are necessary. Study — learn the content, understand the argument, know what the passage actually says. And ask — because all the study in the world will not, of itself, produce a taste for what is there.

Then opened he their understanding, that they might understand the scriptures.

LUKE 24:45

Those disciples had walked with Him for three years and heard the Scriptures all their lives. They still needed their understanding opened, and He opened it.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Before reading Scripture this week, ask specifically to see the beauty of what you read, not merely to understand it.
2. Identify one doctrine you believe correctly and have never found lovely. Bring exactly that one to God and ask for light on it.
3. Test yourself with Edwards's test: does what you know about God produce love for God? Answer honestly rather than quickly.
4. Refuse to substitute strong feeling for spiritual sight. Ask whether a moving experience left you loving holiness or merely loving the experience.
5. If your understanding feels small, take heart, and ask. This light has never been distributed according to cleverness.

A PRAYER

Father, I have read Your Word for years and there are pages I have never seen. I know a great deal about You that has never once moved me.

I cannot manufacture sight. Flesh and blood will not reveal this. So I ask You, who commanded light to shine out of darkness, to shine in my heart.

Do not give me new revelations; give me eyes for what You have already written. Let me taste and see that You are good, and having tasted, let me want nothing else so much. Amen.

The Excellency of Christ

Behold, the Lion of the tribe of Juda ...and I beheld, and, lo, in the midst of the throne ...stood a Lamb as it had been slain.

REVELATION 5:5–6

One of Edwards's most beautiful sermons takes its text from the scene in heaven where the sealed book is opened. John is told to behold a Lion. He turns, and sees a Lamb.

Edwards seized on that. In one Person, in one moment, in one verse: the fiercest of creatures and the gentlest, the conqueror and the sacrifice. And he built from it the theme he called an admirable conjunction of diverse excellencies in Christ Jesus.

Qualities that do not normally combine

His argument depends on an observation about human beings that we all recognise from experience.

In creatures, excellencies tend to exclude one another. A man of towering authority is rarely gentle; a gentle man is rarely commanding. Strict justice and abundant mercy pull against each other in every human judge who has ever tried to hold both. Great dignity does not sit easily with genuine lowliness. We admire people who manage a partial balance, and we notice how rare it is.

In Christ, Edwards said, qualities that in anyone else would be incompatible are found together at their highest degree, and without the least strain.

Infinite majesty, and the humility of a servant. He is Lord of glory, and He washed feet.

Perfect justice, and boundless mercy. He does not relax the law in order to forgive; He satisfies it, and forgives.

Absolute sovereignty, and complete submission. He upholds all things by the word of His power, and He said *not my will, but thine, be done*.

Supreme worthiness of all honour, and patience under the worst dishonour ever offered.

Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God: but made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant ...and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross.

PHILIPPIANS 2:6–8

Edwards's point is not that Christ alternates between these — majestic on Sunday, meek on Monday. It is that they meet in Him simultaneously, and that their meeting is what makes Him unspeakably attractive.

Where the conjunction is clearest

If you want to see it, he said, look at the cross.

At Calvary, Christ's obedience is at its highest and His suffering is at its deepest. His love for sinners and His hatred of sin appear in the same act. His divine glory is most hidden and most displayed at once. The Lion is never more a Lion than when He submits as a Lamb, because it is by dying that He conquers.

*He is despised and rejected of men; a man of sorrows, and acquainted with grief
...he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities.*

ISAIAH 53:3, 5

This is why Edwards regarded the gospel not merely as true but as beautiful. A salvation in which God simply overlooked sin would be less lovely, because justice would have been sacrificed. A salvation in which God merely punished would be less lovely, because mercy would have been absent. What actually happened is more glorious than either, and no one would have invented it.

What this does for the sinner

The pastoral use of the doctrine is direct, and Edwards pressed it hard.

The conjunction of excellencies means there is no state a sinner can be in which does not find its answer in Christ.

Are you afraid of Him? Look at the Lamb. Do you doubt He can help you? Look at the Lion. Do you fear your sin is too great for mercy? His mercy is infinite. Do you fear that mercy means God does not take your sin seriously? Look at what it cost Him.

*Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.
Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart.*

MATTHEW 11:28–29

Edwards observed that the One with the most right to be unapproachable is the most approachable Person who has ever existed — and that this combination, once seen, does more to draw a sinner than any amount of argument.

There is a lesson here about how to commend Christ to others.

We often try to make the gospel attractive by minimising its harder aspects — softening the holiness, muting the judgment. Edwards's approach is the opposite, and far more powerful. Show both. Show the

Lion and the Lamb. The beauty is in the conjunction, and a Christ trimmed to be inoffensive is not more attractive. He is merely smaller.

The Lamb remains a Lamb

There is a detail in the vision that Edwards did not let pass, and it has consequences.

When John turns to see the Lion, what he sees is a Lamb *as it had been slain* — bearing, in glory, the marks of having been killed. This is not a memory of the cross. It is the risen and reigning Christ, and He still carries the wounds.

And they sung a new song, saying, Thou art worthy to take the book, and to open the seals thereof: for thou wast slain, and hast redeemed us to God by thy blood.

REVELATION 5:9

The worship of heaven, in other words, is organised around the crucifixion. The song is not about power in the abstract; it is about a slain Lamb who purchased people at a price. Whatever else eternity contains, the centre of it is the death of Christ for sinners, contemplated for ever by those it saved.

Edwards drew two things from this.

The first is that the condescension of Christ is not a temporary phase now concluded. We might imagine the humility of the incarnation as a season He passed through and left behind on returning to glory. The vision says otherwise. The Lamb is on the throne. The lowliness has been taken up into the glory permanently, which is why the conjunction of excellencies is not an episode but His abiding character.

The second is pastoral, and it goes to the heart of Christian assurance. The One who will judge the world is the One who was judged in the sinner's place, and He appears in the judgment scene still bearing the evidence.

For we have not an high priest which cannot be touched with the feeling of our infirmities; but was in all points tempted like as we are, yet without sin.

HEBREWS 4:15

Edwards pressed the encouragement hard. A believer approaching God is not approaching a stranger to his condition. He comes to One who has been hungry, exhausted, betrayed, misunderstood by His family, abandoned by His friends and executed by the state — and who has not put any of that down.

Let us therefore come boldly unto the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy, and find grace to help in time of need.

HEBREWS 4:16

Boldly, to a throne. The two words do not naturally belong together anywhere else in the universe.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Read Revelation 5 slowly and stop at the moment John turns. Ask what it means that the Lion is a Lamb.
2. Take the pair of qualities in Christ you find hardest to hold together — perhaps His severity and His tenderness — and meditate on the cross, where both appear at once.
3. Notice whether you have quietly trimmed Christ to make Him easier to commend. Restore what you removed.
4. Bring to Him the specific fear that makes you hesitant to approach, and answer it from His character rather than from your performance.
5. Tell someone this week something about Christ that you find beautiful, not merely something you believe is true.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You are the Lion and the Lamb, and I have rarely held both in view at once.

I have made You gentle and forgotten Your majesty, or made You awful and forgotten Your meekness. Forgive me for the smaller Christ I have carried in my mind.

Show me the excellencies that meet in You — justice and mercy, glory and lowliness, sovereignty and obedience — and let the sight of them draw me as no argument ever could.

You are worthy. Let me behold You, and be changed. Amen.

The Beauty of Holiness

O worship the Lord in the beauty of holiness: fear before him, all the earth.

PSALM 96:9

Ask most Christians what holiness is, and you will get an answer about rules. Holiness is not doing certain things; it is separation, restraint, moral seriousness. All of which is true, and all of which Edwards would have said misses the centre entirely.

For Edwards, holiness is first of all *beautiful*. It is the moral loveliness of God, and the reason we so often experience it as a burden is that something has gone wrong with our capacity to perceive beauty.

Holiness as loveliness

In the *Personal Narrative*, describing the change that came over him after his conversion, he wrote about how holiness itself began to appear to him. It struck him as sweet, pleasant, charming, serene and calm — language no one would use of a rulebook.

He described the soul in a state of holiness under the figure of a flower in a field, opening to the sun, quietly receiving light, giving off fragrance, harming nothing.

That is a long way from the grim caricature attached to his name, and it is the authentic Edwards. Holiness is not the absence of pleasure; it is the presence of a superior order of pleasure. It is what a human being looks like when everything in him is rightly proportioned and rightly aimed.

One thing have I desired of the Lord, that will I seek after; that I may dwell in the house of the Lord all the days of my life, to behold the beauty of the Lord, and to enquire in his temple.

PSALM 27:4

Sin as deformity

If holiness is beauty, then sin is not merely rule-breaking. It is ugliness — disorder, distortion, a thing out of proportion.

Edwards found this a far more penetrating way of exposing sin than the merely legal one, and it is worth seeing why.

A man can hear that a certain action is forbidden and feel only that a restriction has been placed on him. He may comply resentfully, looking for the boundary of the rule. But if he is shown that the thing is *ugly*

— that his envy is a deformity, that his self-importance is grotesque, that his harshness with his family is a species of squalor — something different happens. He does not want it any more.

Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice; and be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

EPHESIANS 4:31–32

Put those two verses side by side and consider which is the more beautiful human being. That question, Edwards thought, is not sentimental. It is theological, and it goes deeper than duty.

Why this changes obedience

The consequence for the Christian life is considerable.

If holiness is a rule, obedience is compliance, and compliance is always grudging at the margins. We keep what we must and negotiate the rest. Our sanctification becomes a matter of managing behaviour, and we measure progress by how little we have broken.

If holiness is beauty, obedience becomes desire. We pursue it as a man pursues anything he finds lovely — not because he is required to, but because he wants it.

This is why Edwards insisted that the will is never moved by bare duty alone. The heart follows what it finds attractive. The whole work of grace, in his view, is to change what a person finds attractive, and everything else follows from that.

Delight thyself also in the Lord; and he shall give thee the desires of thine heart.

PSALM 37:4

There is a practical implication for how we teach, and especially for how we raise children in the faith.

A generation instructed only in prohibitions will keep them while supervised and abandon them at the first opportunity, because nothing has been done to their affections. A generation shown that God is beautiful, that holiness is lovely and sin is squalid, has been given something that survives the removal of supervision.

Edwards's own preaching bears this out. He described sin's ugliness relentlessly — but he spent far more time on the loveliness of Christ, because he believed that only a rival beauty can dislodge an old affection.

Shadows of divine things

Edwards kept a private notebook throughout his life which he headed *Images of Divine Things*. In it he recorded the ways the natural world seemed to him to picture spiritual realities.

The rising sun and the coming of grace. The way a river finds the sea.

The silkworm that spins its covering and dies in the labour. The fact that the most beautiful flowers grow in soil made of decay. Hundreds of such entries, made over decades by a man walking and riding through the Connecticut Valley with his mind never off the subject.

This was not idle fancy. It followed directly from his theology of glory. If God made the world to communicate His own fullness, then the world is a kind of language, and everything in it means something beyond itself.

The heavens declare the glory of God; and the firmament sheweth his handy-work.

PSALM 19:1

For the invisible things of him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made.

ROMANS 1:20

The practical value of this habit is considerable, and it is available to anybody.

Most of us pass through a day registering almost nothing. We see weather rather than glory, and traffic rather than providence. Edwards trained himself to look at ordinary things until they yielded something, and the discipline seems to have been a substantial part of how his affections stayed warm through decades of routine.

There is a caution to attach. Edwards's readings are sometimes strained, and a reader can slide into finding secret meanings everywhere, which is a different activity and a less healthy one. The natural world illustrates truth; it does not supply new doctrine. Scripture governs.

But held soberly, the habit is a gift. The believer who has learned to see a sunrise as more than a sunrise — who notices that seed dies before it grows, that light travels vast distances to arrive silently, that a river cannot be prevented from reaching the sea — has been given a thousand daily occasions for worship where he previously had none.

O Lord, how manifold are thy works! in wisdom hast thou made them all: the earth is full of thy riches.

PSALM 104:24

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Take one sin you tolerate. Stop asking whether it is permitted and ask whether it is beautiful. Sit with the answer.
2. Read Psalm 27:4 and ask whether beholding God's beauty is genuinely among the things you desire, or only among the things you approve of.

3. Name a believer whose holiness you find attractive rather than merely impressive. Ask what makes the difference, and pursue that.
4. If you teach or raise children, audit what you say. What proportion is prohibition, and what proportion is the loveliness of Christ?
5. Ask God this week not merely for the strength to obey but for the desire to — for a changed taste rather than a stronger grip.

A PRAYER

Father, You are beautiful, and I have treated Your holiness as a burden to be carried rather than a glory to be enjoyed.

Show me the ugliness of the sin I have been excusing — not only its guilt, but its squalor. And show me the loveliness of Christ, until the comparison does what argument never has.

I do not merely want the strength to obey You. I want to want You. Change my taste, and let obedience follow desire, as it does in every heart that has seen what You are like. Amen.

Original Sin

Behold, I was shapen in iniquity; and in sin did my mother conceive me.

PSALM 51:5

The last book Edwards saw through the press, published in the year he died, was a defence of the doctrine that human nature is corrupt from birth. He wrote it against a popular treatise by an English minister who held that men are born morally neutral and become sinners only by imitation and bad example.

The disagreement sounds technical. It is in fact the difference between two entirely different religions, because everything depends on what is wrong with us.

The argument from the evidence

Edwards's opening move was not a proof text. It was an appeal to the record.

If human beings are born neutral, and sin is merely learned, then somewhere in the history of the world we should expect to find a person who did not learn it, or a society that avoided it. There is no such person and no such society. The pattern is universal, it appears in every culture that has ever existed, and it appears early — long before a child has had time to be corrupted by example.

Universal effects, he argued, require a universal cause. A tree that produces bad fruit in every soil and climate has something wrong with the tree.

And God saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every imagination of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually.

GENESIS 6:5

The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked: who can know it?

JEREMIAH 17:9

Note the second half of that verse, which Edwards found particularly important. Not only is the heart corrupt; it is corrupt in a way that hides itself from the person whose heart it is. Sin includes its own concealment. This is why self-examination is unreliable and why we are most confident precisely where we are most blind.

Not acts but disposition

The heart of the doctrine is that sin is a condition before it is a behaviour.

Wherefore, as by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned.

ROMANS 5:12

We are not sinners because we sin; we sin because we are sinners. The acts are symptoms. And this explains something every honest person notices about himself: that his failures are not random accidents but have a consistent direction. The same faults recur across decades. Something is bent, not merely occasionally misused.

Edwards described the essence of that bentness with unusual precision. Man was made to love God supremely and all other things in proportion to their worth. In the fall, that ordering collapsed, and the self moved into the position God had occupied. What remains is not the absence of love but love wrongly centred — a private system in which everything is valued by its usefulness to me.

This accounts for why so much apparent virtue is hollow. A man may be generous, disciplined and kind, and be so entirely for himself — for his reputation, his self-image, his comfort. The behaviour is admirable and the centre is unchanged.

Among whom also we all had our conversation in times past in the lusts of our flesh ...and were by nature the children of wrath, even as others.

EPHESIANS 2:3

By nature. Not by choice, not by imitation. By what we are.

Where Edwards is contested

Honesty requires a note here, and it concerns not the doctrine but Edwards's particular explanation of it.

The difficulty every theologian faces is how we can be justly implicated in the act of a man who lived before us. Edwards's answer, worked out in the later part of the treatise, is that the unity of the human race with Adam rests on a divine constitution — that identity over time, even the identity of a single person with himself from one moment to the next, is not a natural fact but something God continuously establishes. On that basis, God constitutes the race one with its head.

It is an ingenious argument and it has never commanded general assent. Many careful readers who hold the doctrine of original sin firmly find this particular account speculative, and some think it proves too much. Others prefer the more traditional explanation of Adam as covenant head representing his posterity.

The reader should feel free to hold the doctrine and set the explanation aside. Scripture asserts the fact plainly and does not supply the mechanism. Edwards's attempt to supply one is interesting; it is not binding.

The practical value of this doctrine is that it makes the gospel intelligible.

If the problem were bad habits, we would need instruction. If it were bad company, we would need a better environment. If it were ignorance, we would need education. Christianity has been repeatedly reduced to each of these, and each reduction produces a religion of self-improvement.

If the problem is a corrupt nature, then nothing will do but a new birth — and that is precisely what is offered.

Marvel not that I said unto thee, Ye must be born again.

JOHN 3:7

The kindness of a severe diagnosis

It is worth pausing to notice that this doctrine, which sounds so bleak, is in several respects a mercy.

A severe diagnosis is kinder than a false one. If a man is gravely ill, the physician who tells him he is a little run down and should take more exercise is not being gentle; he is killing him politely. The doctor who names the disease accurately is the one who can treat it.

Edwards understood the alternative accounts on offer, and they have only multiplied since. We are told our problems are the result of upbringing, environment, poor education, unmet needs, or bad social arrangements. Each contains truth. None accounts for the universality of the pattern, and each locates the fault somewhere other than in the person himself — which sounds compassionate and leaves him helpless, since he cannot change his history.

There is also an equality in this doctrine that is easily missed and worth dwelling on.

If sin is a condition we all share from birth, then the ground before God is entirely level. The respectable and the disgraced differ in how far the disease has visibly progressed, not in whether they have it. The person whose sins are socially acceptable — coldness, pride, quiet contempt, comfortable indifference to suffering — is not further along than the person whose sins are visible and shameful. He is merely better camouflaged.

For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God.

ROMANS 3:23

This is why Edwards regarded the doctrine as an enemy of self-

righteousness rather than a source of despair. Nobody who genuinely believes it can look down on anyone, because he has no ground on which to stand and look down from.

And it makes the gospel proportionate. A God who offered advice to people who needed only advice would be adequate. A God who raises the dead is what the situation actually requires.

Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ; (by grace ye are saved).

EPHESIANS 2:5

Dead people are not improved. They are raised, or they stay as they are. That is the whole difference between Christianity and every scheme of moral betterment that has ever been proposed.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Look at your recurring faults over ten years, not ten days. Ask what the consistency of their direction tells you.
2. Take one genuinely good thing you have done recently and examine the centre of it. Who was it finally for?
3. Stop treating your sin as a series of incidents to be managed and start treating it as a condition to be healed.
4. Where you feel most confident of your own integrity, ask God to search you there specifically. That is where Jeremiah 17:9 applies.
5. Thank God for the new birth — a remedy proportionate to the actual disease.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have wanted to believe my sins are incidents, and You tell me they are symptoms.

I confess that the fault is not in my circumstances or my upbringing or the people around me. It is in me, and it was in me before I could choose it.

Search me where I am most sure of myself, for that is where I am most deceived.

And thank You that You did not offer me instruction when I needed resurrection. I cannot reform what You have said must be born again. Do in me what only You can do. Amen.

The Freedom of the Will

And ye will not come to me, that ye might have life.

JOHN 5:40

In 1754, from a frontier village, Edwards published the book that made his reputation as a philosopher. Its full title is forbidding and its argument is dense, but the distinction at its centre is one of the most practically useful tools in pastoral theology.

It answers a question every believer eventually asks. If a sinner cannot come to God without grace, how can he be blamed for not coming?

Two kinds of cannot

Edwards's answer turns on distinguishing two things we confuse because English uses one word for both.

There is **natural inability**. A man cannot fly. A prisoner in chains cannot leave. A blind man cannot see the sunrise. In each case something outside the person's will prevents him, and nobody holds him responsible. We do not blame the prisoner for staying in his cell.

There is **moral inability**. A devoted mother cannot bring herself to harm her child. A man of settled integrity cannot be induced to betray his friend. Here nothing external prevents anything. The person has every faculty required. What he lacks is the inclination — and the stronger his character, the more truly we say he *cannot*.

Notice that in the second case, the inability is not an excuse. It is a description of the person's heart, and we praise or blame people precisely for this kind of cannot.

The sinner's inability, Edwards argued, is entirely of the second kind. He has understanding, will and conscience. Nothing binds his hands. What he lacks is any desire for God — and that lack is not his misfortune, it is his sin.

No man can come to me, except the Father which hath sent me draw him.

JOHN 6:44

Because the carnal mind is enmity against God: for it is not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can be.

ROMANS 8:7

Both verses say *cannot*. Neither offers it as an excuse. Set them beside *ye will not come to me*, and the two are the same fact described from two angles: the cannot is a will not.

What freedom actually is

Behind this lies Edwards's account of the will itself.

He argued that the will is not some neutral faculty hovering above our desires, choosing between them from a position of indifference. The will always follows what appears most desirable to the person at the moment of choosing. We invariably choose what we most want.

Freedom, then, is not the power to choose against your strongest desire — which would be a strange thing to want, and would make every choice random rather than responsible. Freedom is being able to act according to your desire without external constraint. The prisoner is unfree; the man who stays home because he prefers to is entirely free, even though his choice was certain.

This is why responsibility survives. You are responsible not because your choices were uncaused, but because they were *yours* — they came from what you actually wanted.

Can the Ethiopian change his skin, or the leopard his spots? then may ye also do good, that are accustomed to do evil.

JEREMIAH 13:23

Where readers differ

This is Edwards's most philosophically contested work, and readers should know it.

Many thoughtful Christians hold that genuine moral responsibility requires the real ability to have chosen otherwise, and that Edwards's account, however carefully argued, ultimately makes God the author of sin. Others find the distinction between natural and moral inability decisive and the objection answered. The debate has continued for two and a half centuries without resolution, and it will not be settled here.

What is not in dispute among those who take Scripture seriously is the pastoral substance: that sinners are genuinely unable to save themselves, that they are genuinely responsible, and that both are taught in the same passages.

The practical use of the distinction is considerable, and it works in two directions.

It removes the sinner's excuse. A person who says he would come to Christ if he could is invited to examine what is actually stopping him. Nothing external is. He does not come because he does not want to, and that is not a limitation to be pitied but a heart to be repented of.

And it directs prayer accurately. If the obstacle were natural, we would need circumstances changed. Because it is moral, we ask God to change the wanting. That is precisely what He has promised to do.

A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh.

EZEKIEL 36:26

Both at once

The obvious question raised by this chapter is how divine sovereignty and human responsibility can both be fully true. Edwards's answer, stripped of its philosophical machinery, is that Scripture asserts both without apology and we are not at liberty to drop either.

The clearest case is the one every Christian already accepts without noticing.

Wherefore, my beloved ...work out your own salvation with fear and trembling. For it is God which worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure.

PHILIPPIANS 2:12–13

Notice the logic of that *for*. Paul does not say: work hard, because God has done His part and the rest is up to you. He says: work, *because* God is at work in you — and God's work extends to the willing itself. The divine activity is offered as the ground of the human activity, not its replacement.

This is the pattern throughout Scripture. God commands what only He can give, and gives what He commands.

Make you a new heart and a new spirit: for why will ye die, O house of Israel?

EZEKIEL 18:31

A new heart also will I give you ...and I will put my spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes.

EZEKIEL 36:26–27

The same prophet, in the same book, commands the people to make themselves a new heart and promises that God will give them one. Edwards regarded this as decisive. If the two were genuinely incompatible, Ezekiel would not have written both.

The practical consequence is a refusal of both errors that this doctrine tends to produce.

The first error is fatalism — the conclusion that since God is sovereign, effort is pointless. Edwards's response is that God ordains means as well as ends, and that our striving is one of the means through which He accomplishes His purpose. Nobody argues that since God has appointed the harvest we need not plant.

The second error is self-reliance — treating the commands as though we could meet them unaided. That is precisely the error the whole treatise exists to demolish.

The believer's position is therefore to work as hard as if it depended on him, and to pray as one who knows perfectly well that it does not.

Edwards saw no tension there at all, and neither, apparently, did Paul.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Where you say you cannot obey God in some matter, test which kind of cannot it is. Is anything actually preventing you but your own unwillingness?
2. Change how you pray for the unconverted. Ask God to give them a new wanting, not merely a new opportunity.
3. Stop waiting to feel willing before you act. Obedience frequently precedes desire, and desire follows.
4. Hold this doctrine with humility. Sincere believers differ here, and it is not a test of orthodoxy.
5. Take Ezekiel 36:26 as a personal request for the area of your life that feels most immovable.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have said that I could not, when the truth is that I would not.

Take away the excuse. Show me that nothing stands between me and obedience except a heart that does not want what You want.

I cannot repair my own wanting. So I ask for what You promised: take out the heart of stone and give me a heart of flesh.

Make me willing, and then hold me to it. Amen.

Justification by Faith Alone

*But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the
ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness.*

ROMANS 4:5

In November 1734 Edwards preached a series of sermons at Northampton on justification by faith alone. He was answering a drift in New England towards a comfortable moralism in which decent behaviour was quietly assumed to secure God's favour.

What followed was not a theological controversy. It was a revival. Within months the town was transformed, and Edwards always maintained that the doctrine and the awakening were connected — that people were converted precisely when they stopped trying to contribute.

Justifying the ungodly

The scandal is in the text, and Edwards would not let his hearers soften it.

Paul does not say that God justifies the repentant, or the sincere, or those doing their best. He says God justifies *the ungodly*. The person declared righteous is, at the moment of the declaration, not righteous.

*Being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus
...Therefore we conclude that a man is justified by faith without the deeds of the
law.*

ROMANS 3:24, 28

Justification is a legal declaration, not a description of our condition. God does not inspect us and find us acceptable. He credits to us a righteousness that belongs to another and treats us accordingly.

*And be found in him, not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law,
but that which is through the faith of Christ, the righteousness which is of God by
faith.*

PHILIPPIANS 3:9

How faith justifies — and how it does not

Here Edwards made a distinction of great precision, and it protects the doctrine from the most common way of ruining it.

The natural assumption is that faith is the one thing God accepts in place of works — that whereas the law demanded obedience we could not render, the gospel demands only belief, which we can manage. On

that view faith has become a very small work, and we are back to being saved by something we do.

Edwards rejected this firmly. Faith does not justify as a virtue, as though God were rewarding us for believing. Faith justifies because it *unites* us to Christ. Its whole value is in its object.

The illustration usually given is exact: a drowning man is not saved by the excellence of his grip but by the strength of the one who holds him. A weak hand on a strong rescuer is enough. A strong hand on nothing is not.

This is why assurance need not depend on the quality of our believing. The question is not whether your faith is impressive but whether Christ is sufficient.

Justification and the life that follows

Edwards was equally firm at the other boundary, and this matters, because he is sometimes read as though his emphasis on holy living compromises free justification.

It does not. He held both, and he held them in the biblical order.

Justification is by faith alone, entirely apart from works, received at once and complete. And the faith that justifies is never alone — it invariably produces a changed life, because it unites us to a living Christ, and union with Him cannot leave a person as he was.

For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them.

EPHESIANS 2:10

Works are the evidence, never the ground. Edwards's later insistence on Christian practice as the great sign of grace, which we shall come to, rests entirely on this footing. He was not adding works to faith. He was pointing out that a tree is known by its fruit without the fruit having grown the tree.

There is a reason this doctrine produced revival rather than complacency, and it is worth understanding, because we might expect the opposite.

Moralism is exhausting and it never delivers assurance, because the standard is always just beyond reach and the conscience is never quiet. What it produces is either despair or self-deception.

Free justification ends the exhaustion. And the person who has actually stopped paying discovers that gratitude motivates far more powerfully than fear ever did. Edwards watched a whole town discover this in a single winter.

The great exchange

Behind the doctrine of justification lies a transaction that Scripture states with startling economy.

For he hath made him to be sin for us, who knew no sin; that we might be made the righteousness of God in him.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:21

Two transfers in a single sentence, running in opposite directions. Our sin is reckoned to Christ, who had none. His righteousness is reckoned to us, who have none. Neither transfer is a legal fiction in the sense of a pretence; both rest on a real union, which is why faith — the instrument of that union — is the means by which the whole thing is received.

Edwards laid stress on the completeness of what is credited. The righteousness imputed is not a fresh start, a clean sheet, or a reduced sentence. It is the entire active and passive obedience of Christ — everything He did in His life and everything He bore in His death — placed to our account.

This means the believer does not stand before God as forgiven but unproven. He stands as one who has kept the law perfectly, because Another kept it for him.

For as by one man's disobedience many were made sinners, so by the obedience of one shall many be made righteous.

ROMANS 5:19

The practical weight of this falls on assurance, and it addresses the most common disorder among sincere Christians.

Believers who understand that their sins are forgiven often still live as though their standing fluctuates — better after a good week, worse after a bad one. The reason is that they are thinking only of the first transfer. Forgiveness removes a debt and leaves the account at zero, and from zero one must presumably begin earning again.

The second transfer ends that arithmetic. The account is not at zero; it is full, and it was filled by someone whose performance does not vary. There is nothing to earn, because nothing is missing.

There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus.

ROMANS 8:1

Edwards preached this to a congregation that had spent generations quietly assuming that respectability counted for something with God. Within months, a town that had been trying to be good enough discovered it had never needed to be, and could not stop talking about it.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask whether you are trusting Christ or trusting the quality of your trust. The difference determines where you look when assurance falters.
2. Identify one way you are still trying to earn God's favour. Name it, and renounce it specifically.
3. Read Romans 4:5 aloud and let the phrase *justifieth the ungodly* stand without qualification.
4. Check the order in your own thinking: are good works your ground of acceptance, or the evidence of it?
5. When you fail this week, do not set about repairing your standing. Return to a righteousness that was never yours in the first place.

A PRAYER

Father, I have been trying to bring You something.

You justify the ungodly, and I have laboured for years to arrive at Your court as something other than that. Forgive the pride hidden in all my striving.

I have no righteousness of my own. I take the righteousness of Christ, credited to me, which I did not earn and cannot lose.

And now that nothing depends on my performance, let gratitude do in me what fear never could. Amen.

Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God

Their foot shall slide in due time.

DEUTERONOMY 32:35

On the eighth of July, 1741, Edwards rode to Enfield, a town that had so far been untouched by the awakening spreading through the valley, and preached the sermon everyone remembers.

He did not shout it. By all accounts he read it in a level voice from a manuscript held close to his short-sighted eyes, with little gesture. The congregation began crying out before he had finished, and he had to pause. The power was not in the delivery.

What he actually argued

The doctrine drawn from the text is a single sentence: there is nothing keeping wicked men out of hell at any moment except the mere pleasure of God.

Everything else in the sermon is an unfolding of that. The unconverted are not safe because they are healthy, because they are respectable, because they intend to repent later, or because nothing has happened to them yet. They are suspended over destruction by nothing but the will of the God they have offended.

The images are famous and they are relentless. A bow bent, the arrow on the string. Waters dammed and rising. A spider held over a flame. Rotten ground underfoot that gives way without warning.

It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God.

HEBREWS 10:31

Modern readers find this intolerable, and it is worth asking honestly why. Part of the reason is that we have lost any strong sense that sin is an outrage against an infinitely worthy God. Edwards's logic here follows directly from his first principle: if God's worth is infinite, then contempt for Him is infinitely serious, and the punishment is not disproportionate at all.

The half nobody quotes

What is almost never quoted is where the sermon goes.

Having spent the doctrine section establishing the danger, Edwards turns to the application, and the application is not condemnation. It is invitation. He tells his hearers that this is an extraordinary opportunity

— a day when Christ has flung the door of mercy wide open and stands calling. He points to others already coming in. He urges them not to be the ones who miss it.

The sermon is not designed to make people despair. It is designed to make them run. Every terror in it exists to move a congregation towards a door that Edwards insists is open.

Knowing therefore the terror of the Lord, we persuade men.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:11

That is precisely the structure: terror, and therefore persuasion.

How to read it, and how not to

Three cautions are necessary, and Edwards's own body of work supplies all of them.

First, this sermon is not representative. Roughly twelve hundred of his sermons survive, and the great majority are about the excellency of Christ, the beauty of holiness, the love of God and the joys of heaven. He preached far more on heaven than on hell. To take this one as the summary of his ministry is like judging a composer by four bars.

Second, the terror is never freestanding. It rests on the glory of God, and it is always aimed at mercy. Preaching that reproduces the imagery without the theology — that uses fear as a technique to produce responses — is not following Edwards. It is borrowing his most quotable paragraph and discarding his argument.

Third, and this must be said plainly: this material has done real harm when misapplied. Used on children, on the tender-conscienced, on the mentally fragile, or on believers already crushed, it produces terror without hope and damage that can last a lifetime. Edwards was preaching to a specific congregation of self-satisfied and largely unconverted townspeople. That is not every congregation, and it is not most individuals in pastoral distress. Scripture itself distinguishes: *of some have compassion, making a difference: and others save with fear* (Jude 22–23).

There remains something here the modern church badly needs, and it would be cowardly to end the chapter without saying it.

We have very largely stopped believing that anything is at stake. We speak of faith as a source of meaning, community and peace — all of which it is — and we have quietly dropped the possibility that a person might be lost. Edwards believed the danger was real, and his urgency followed from it.

If he was wrong, he wasted a great deal of passion. If he was right, our composure is difficult to justify.

I tell you, Nay: but, except ye repent, ye shall all likewise perish.

LUKE 13:3

Wrath and love in one God

The modern difficulty with this sermon is not really about its imagery. It is that we cannot see how a God of wrath and a God of love can be the same God, and so we quietly keep one and discard the other.

Edwards held both, and the way he held them is instructive.

He did not regard wrath as an emotion God has, still less as divine irritability. Wrath is the settled and appropriate response of a holy God to what is genuinely evil. A judge who felt nothing at cruelty would not be more loving than one who did; he would be defective. Indifference to evil is not a virtue in anyone, and we do not admire it in human beings.

So the wrath of God is not the opposite of His love. It is what His love looks like when it confronts what destroys the beloved.

He that believeth on the Son hath everlasting life: and he that believeth not the Son shall not see life; but the wrath of God abideth on him.

JOHN 3:36

That verse comes a few lines after the best-known statement of God's love in the Bible, in the same chapter, from the same speaker. Whoever wrote John 3:16 saw no contradiction.

And the resolution is not a compromise between the two. It is the cross.

But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us. Much more then, being now justified by his blood, we shall be saved from wrath through him.

ROMANS 5:8–9

At Calvary the wrath is not waived, minimised or explained away. It falls — and it falls on God Himself, in the person of His Son, so that it need not fall on those He came to save. Edwards's whole point in the Enfield sermon is that there is a place where this wrath has already been exhausted, and that the door to it stands open.

Which means the sermon is finally about the cross, even where it never mentions it. Every terror in it presupposes a refuge, and the refuge is the reason the terror is being described at all.

A gospel with no wrath has nothing to be saved from, and a gospel with no cross has nowhere to run. Edwards preached both, and the second was always the point.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask whether you actually believe anyone is in danger. Your evangelistic urgency will never exceed your honest answer.

2. If you preach or teach, examine whether you use fear as a technique. Terror that is not aimed at an open door is manipulation.
3. Consider whom you are speaking to. Scripture requires different treatment for the hardened and the fragile.
4. Read one of Edwards's sermons on heaven or the love of Christ this month, so that this one sits in its proper proportion.
5. Name one person for whom you have grown comfortable with their being unconverted. Repent of the comfort.

A PRAYER

*Lord God, I have made my peace with things You have not made Your peace with.
I have believed in Your love and quietly stopped believing in Your judgment, and my
urgency has drained away accordingly.
Restore to me a right sense of what is at stake — not a fear that paralyses, but a
seriousness that moves me towards the people around me.
And keep me from cruelty. Let me never use terror as a tool, or press upon a bruised
soul what belongs to the hardened. Give me the wisdom to know the difference.
Amen.*

True Religion Consists in Holy Affections

*Whom having not seen, ye love; in whom, though now ye see him not,
yet believing, ye rejoice with joy unspeakable and full of glory.*

1 PETER 1:8

In 1746, with the Great Awakening behind him and its wreckage plainly visible, Edwards published *A Treatise Concerning Religious Affections*. It is his masterpiece, and it was written by a man who had watched thousands profess conversion and had lived long enough to see how many of them lasted.

Its opening thesis is deceptively simple: true religion consists, in great part, in holy affections.

What he meant by affections

Everything depends on getting this word right, and modern English makes it difficult.

By affections Edwards did not mean emotions in our sense — moods, feelings, the weather of the inner life. He meant the vigorous inclinations of the soul: the settled loves and hatreds, longings and aversions, by which a person is actually moved. An affection is what you are inclined towards with your whole self.

He distinguished these carefully from what he called the passions, which are more sudden, more bodily, and more likely to overwhelm. Passions come and go. Affections direct a life.

The claim, then, is not that religion consists in having strong feelings during worship. It is that religion consists in the heart being genuinely inclined towards God — and that where this inclination is absent, whatever else is present is not saving faith.

*And thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul,
and with all thy might.*

DEUTERONOMY 6:5

Against two errors at once

Edwards was writing between two parties, and the treatise attacks both.

On one side stood those who concluded from the excesses of the revival that emotion in religion is inherently suspect — that the safe course is doctrine soberly held and duty quietly performed. Edwards regarded this as a catastrophic misreading of Scripture. The Bible commands love, joy, hope, godly sorrow, zeal, hunger and thirst. A religion

that never engages the affections is not more spiritual than one that does; it is dead.

Not slothful in business; fervent in spirit; serving the Lord.

ROMANS 12:11

So then because thou art lukewarm, and neither cold nor hot, I will spue thee out of my mouth.

REVELATION 3:16

On the other side stood those who took any strong religious feeling as evidence of grace — who counted tears, ecstasies and dramatic experiences as proof. Edwards regarded this as equally disastrous, and the bulk of the treatise is devoted to dismantling it.

His position is that the presence of strong affections proves nothing by itself, and their absence proves a great deal. Feeling is necessary but not sufficient. That is a harder line to hold than either extreme, and it is why the book satisfied neither party.

Why the heart is the issue

Behind this lies Edwards's whole anthropology.

He did not believe that the will is moved by reason alone. Knowledge that leaves the heart cold changes nothing — we all know a great many true things we do not act on. What actually moves a person is what he loves. The affections are therefore not a decorative addition to the Christian life; they are its engine.

This is why a merely intellectual conversion is not conversion. A man may revise his opinions about God without his loves being touched at all, and he will remain exactly the person he was, better informed.

And it explains the direction of Edwards's whole ministry. If the heart follows what it finds beautiful, then the preacher's task is not principally to inform or to persuade but to display — to hold up Christ until the affections move.

There is a diagnostic question here that is worth carrying about.

Not: do you believe the right things? Many do who are unchanged.
Not: do you feel strongly in church? Many do who are unchanged.

But: what do you love? What genuinely delights you, grieves you, occupies you when nothing requires it? Those answers, Edwards thought, are the truest map of a soul that exists.

How much of Scripture is affection

Edwards supported his thesis by an argument from sheer volume, and it is worth following, because it is difficult to answer.

Consider how much of what Scripture commands is an affection rather than an action.

We are commanded to **love** God and neighbour, which the Lord Himself identified as the greatest commandments. We are commanded to **fear** God, to **hope** in Him, to **rejoice** in Him always, to **hunger and thirst** after righteousness, to **delight** in His law, to be **zealous** of good works, to be **fervent** in spirit, to have **compassion** on the afflicted, to **hate** evil, to **mourn** over sin, to be **thankful** in everything, to **long** for the appearing of Christ.

Every one of those is a state of the heart. None can be produced by decision alone, and none can be faked for long.

My soul thirsteth for God, for the living God: when shall I come and appear before God?

PSALM 42:2

Now consider the saints themselves. The Psalms, which are the church's prayerbook, are almost entirely affection — longing, grief, exultation, dread, gratitude, rage at injustice. David dances. Jeremiah weeps. Paul is willing to be accursed for his kinsmen. The Lord Jesus weeps at a grave, is moved with compassion, rejoices in spirit, is grieved at hardness of heart, and sweats in agony in a garden.

Jesus wept.

JOHN 11:35

Edwards's conclusion was that a religion which engages the intellect and the will while leaving the affections untouched bears no resemblance to the religion described in the Bible. Whatever such a thing is, it is not what Scripture is talking about.

He added one further observation, and it disposes of a common objection. People sometimes plead temperament — that they are simply not emotional by nature, and that their faith is quieter than others'. Edwards allowed for real differences of constitution. But he noticed that the same people who report themselves incapable of strong feeling in religion are frequently capable of considerable passion about money, politics, reputation, sport or family.

The affections are working. The question is what they are attached to.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask what you actually delight in, as distinct from what you approve of. The gap between those two lists is the honest measure of your heart.
2. If your faith has become entirely cerebral, admit it. Ask God to move your affections, not merely to inform your mind.

3. If your faith runs on experiences, admit that too, and start testing them by the marks in the next chapters.
4. Notice what grieves you this week. Are you troubled by the things that grieve God, or only by the things that inconvenience you?
5. Spend time deliberately beholding Christ rather than analysing yourself. The affections follow the gaze.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have held true things about You without loving You, and I have felt strongly in Your presence without being changed.

Deliver me from a religion of the head that never reaches the heart, and from a religion of the feelings that never reaches the life.

Give me holy affections — real love for what You love, real grief over what grieves You, real longing for Your presence when nothing compels me.

Show me Christ until my heart moves. Amen.

Distinguishing Marks

Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God.

1 JOHN 4:1

In September 1741, at the height of the awakening, Edwards preached at the Yale commencement to an audience that included many of the movement's fiercest critics. The address was published as *The Distinguishing Marks of a Work of the Spirit of God*.

The situation demanded it. The revival had produced genuine conversions and also outcry, fainting, visions, itinerant preachers denouncing settled ministers, and men claiming direct messages from God. One party declared the whole thing a work of the Spirit; the other declared it hysteria.

Edwards refused both, and set about supplying tests.

Nine things that prove nothing

The first half of the argument is negative, and it is the more original half. Edwards lists things which, contrary to what both parties assumed, are no evidence either way.

That a work is unusual, or conducted in ways not seen before, proves nothing. God is not obliged to repeat His methods, and novelty is neither a recommendation nor an objection.

That it produces bodily effects — tears, trembling, groaning, fainting, collapse — proves nothing. Edwards granted that a real apprehension of eternal things might well overwhelm a frame of flesh and blood. He also granted that such effects can be produced by suggestion, crowd excitement and imagination. Therefore they settle nothing.

That there is a great deal of noise and talk about religion proves nothing. That people are strongly impressed in their imaginations proves nothing. That the preaching dwells much on terror proves nothing. That some who are affected are self-deceived proves nothing about the rest.

And — this is the point his critics could not accept — that the movement contains errors, imprudences and even scandals proves nothing about its origin. Edwards observed that no revival in Scripture or history has ever been free of human folly, because revivals happen among human beings. The corruption of converts is not evidence against their conversion; it is evidence that they have not yet been perfected.

Five things that prove a great deal

Having cleared the ground, he takes his positive tests directly from 1 John 4, and they are as useful today as they were in 1741.

Does it raise the esteem of Jesus? Where a work leads people to a higher view of Christ as the Son of God and the only Saviour, that is a mark Satan will not counterfeit, because it is against his interest.

Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is of God.

1 JOHN 4:2

Does it work against sin and worldliness? A movement that draws people away from worldly lusts and the pursuits of this life is not being driven by the god of this world, who has no interest in emptying his own kingdom.

Does it increase regard for Scripture? Genuine work of the Spirit establishes people in the Word. Anything that leads people to prize their own impressions above the written Word — however spiritual it sounds — is moving the wrong way.

Does it lead to truth? The Spirit of truth convinces people of things that are actually so: their own sinfulness, the reality of judgment, the sufficiency of Christ.

Does it produce love to God and man? This is the mark Edwards weighted most heavily. Not excitement, not zeal, not activity — love. And he noted the counterfeit precisely: a fierce, censorious, divisive spirit that condemns other Christians while claiming superior spirituality is not the Spirit of God, whatever else it may be.

Beloved, let us love one another: for love is of God; and every one that loveth is born of God, and knoweth God.

1 JOHN 4:7

The lasting value of this little book is its refusal of the easy verdict.

Both parties in 1741 wanted a single judgment: it is all God, or it is all delusion. Edwards insisted on the harder and more accurate position — that in any real move of God among real people, genuine grace and human excess will be mixed, and the work of discernment is to separate them rather than to endorse or condemn the whole.

That remains the mature Christian posture, and it is uncomfortable in exactly the same way today.

Judging works, not hearts

Edwards attached an important limitation to everything in this chapter, and ignoring it has done a great deal of harm.

The marks are given for judging a *work* — a movement, a ministry, a general phenomenon — and for examining oneself. They are not given for pronouncing on the spiritual state of individuals.

He was emphatic about this because the awakening had produced exactly that abuse. Confident young converts were declaring particular ministers unconverted, dividing congregations on the strength of their own discernment, and treating their impressions about other people's souls as revelation. Edwards regarded this as one of the most damaging things that happened in those years, and he said so at real cost to his standing with the movement's enthusiasts.

Therefore judge nothing before the time, until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the hearts.

1 CORINTHIANS 4:5

His reasoning was consistent with everything else he taught. If the heart is deceitful above all things and unknowable even to its owner, then our confidence about someone else's inner state is absurd. We see conduct; we do not see the soul. God alone reads hearts, and He has not delegated the function.

For the Lord seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh on the outward appearance, but the Lord looketh on the heart.

1 SAMUEL 16:7

This does not mean we are forbidden all judgment. Edwards was clear that we may and must assess teaching, evaluate conduct, and exercise discipline in the church where sin is open. What is forbidden is the confident verdict on another's standing before God.

There is a rule of thumb implicit in his practice that is worth adopting. Apply the strictest tests to yourself and the most charitable reading to others. Most of us do the reverse instinctively, and call it discernment.

Charity suffereth long, and is kind ...beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:4, 7

Believeth all things, hopeth all things. That is not naivety. It is the posture of someone who knows he cannot see what only God can see, and who has decided which way to lean in the absence of certainty.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Apply the five positive tests to any movement or ministry you are assessing — including your own church, and including yourself.
2. Stop treating manifestations as evidence in either direction. Ask what they produce over five years, not what they look like in the moment.

3. Where you have dismissed a whole work because of its excesses, reconsider. Separate the wheat from the chaff instead of burning the field.
4. Watch for the counterfeit of the fifth mark: zeal that condemns other believers is not love, however spiritual it sounds.
5. Ask whether your own spiritual experiences have left you esteeming Christ more highly and loving people more truly. If not, hold them loosely.

A PRAYER

Lord, give me discernment without cynicism, and openness without gullibility. I am prone to one or the other and rarely to both at once.

Where You are at work, let me not oppose You because the packaging offends me. Where there is deception, let me not embrace it because the feeling was strong.

Test my own experience by Your marks: does it exalt Christ, turn me from the world, drive me to Your Word, lead me into truth, and make me love?

If it does not, I would rather know. Amen.

Signs of Gracious Affections

Examine yourselves, whether ye be in the faith; prove your own selves.

2 CORINTHIANS 13:5

Having shown that strong religious feeling proves nothing by itself, Edwards faced the obvious question. What, then, does prove something?

The longest part of *Religious Affections* answers it with twelve signs. They are not a checklist to be scored, and Edwards said so explicitly — he warned that no set of marks can enable us to judge another person's heart with certainty, and that some of them are visible only to the person himself. They are given for self-examination, and they are pointed.

Five of them are particularly searching.

Loved for Himself, or for His usefulness

The second sign asks what the affections are actually fixed upon.

Counterfeit religious joy, Edwards observed, characteristically begins with the self. A person becomes convinced that God loves him, that he is forgiven, that he is destined for heaven — and from this arises great gladness. Notice that every element of that joy is about his own good fortune. God appears in it only as the source of his benefit.

Gracious affections begin at the other end. They are drawn first by what God is in Himself — His holiness, His truth, His beauty — and the personal benefit follows as a consequence rather than founding the whole structure.

The test is uncomfortable and it is fair. Would God still be lovely to you if He gave you nothing further? Is your delight in Him, or in your standing with Him?

Whom have I in heaven but thee? and there is none upon earth that I desire beside thee.

PSALM 73:25

Evangelical humiliation

The sixth sign is a particular kind of lowliness, and Edwards distinguished it sharply from a counterfeit.

There is a natural humiliation — a sense of one's own smallness, failure or inadequacy — which any person may feel and which produces mostly despair or self-pity. It is essentially a wounded self, still very much at the centre.

Evangelical humiliation is different. It is the sense of one's own utter insufficiency arising from a sight of God's holiness, and its effect is not despair but relief. The soul stops defending itself and is glad to.

Edwards regarded this as one of the most reliable marks, and he noted its inversion: the more genuine grace a person has, the smaller he appears to himself. Growth in holiness is accompanied by a growing sense of remaining sin, which is why mature saints so often describe themselves in terms younger believers find excessive.

*I have heard of thee by the hearing of the ear: but now mine eye seeth thee.
Wherefore I abhor myself, and repent in dust and ashes.*

JOB 42:5–6

The temper of Christ

The eighth sign is the character of Jesus reproduced — what Edwards called the lamblike, dovelike spirit.

Here he confronted the most damaging phenomenon of the awakening. A great many people had become extremely zealous and extremely harsh: quick to denounce, confident about others' spiritual state, contemptuous of ministers they judged unconverted. They regarded their severity as evidence of their earnestness.

Edwards's judgment was blunt. A censorious, bitter, quarrelsome spirit is not a sign of grace no matter how orthodox its opinions, because it is not the temper of the Lamb.

Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart.

MATTHEW 11:29

Symmetry, and an appetite that grows

The tenth sign is proportion. Grace produces a balanced character rather than a lopsided one. The counterfeit is recognisable: enormous zeal in one department and nothing in another — fierce about doctrine and careless about money, scrupulous in worship and cruel at home, generous in public and unkind in private. Real grace touches everything, unevenly perhaps, but everywhere.

The eleventh sign is the most encouraging in the list. False affections tend to satisfy — the person feels he has arrived, and his hunger diminishes. Gracious affections do the opposite: the more a soul receives, the more it wants. Spiritual appetite increases with feeding.

Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness: for they shall be filled.

MATTHEW 5:6

A word of pastoral caution, which Edwards himself supplied.

These signs can be used destructively. A tender believer already prone to introspection may work through such a list and conclude he

has no grace at all, when in fact the very anxiety he feels is evidence of a heart that cares.

Edwards was aware of this and warned against endless self-examination. The signs are for occasional honest review, not for daily audit. And the remedy when they trouble you is not more inspection but more looking away — to Christ, in whom the assurance is finally located.

A new nature, not a new mood

Two further signs from the list deserve attention, because together they set the frame for all the others.

The first sign is that gracious affections arise from a spiritual and supernatural influence on the heart — something genuinely new, not a heightened version of what was already there.

This distinction runs through everything Edwards wrote about conversion. A natural person may be moved by religion in entirely natural ways. He may be stirred by beautiful music, gripped by a powerful speaker, frightened by thoughts of death, comforted by a sense of belonging. None of these requires the Spirit of God, and all of them can produce tears and resolutions and a temporary change of life.

What grace produces is different in kind. It is a new spiritual sense — the capacity treated in chapter four — and it perceives an excellence in divine things that natural faculties cannot detect at all.

Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.

JOHN 3:3

The seventh sign follows from this: gracious affections are attended with a change of nature.

Edwards insisted that grace does not merely add religious activities to an unchanged person. It alters the disposition itself, so that what a person fundamentally wants is different. The change may be gradual in its outworking and is often invisible at first, but it is a change in the person, not merely in his behaviour or his schedule.

Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:17

He added a qualification that has comforted many. The old nature is not eradicated, and the change is not complete in this life. A true convert still finds sin in himself, sometimes to his dismay, and the presence of that struggle is not evidence against conversion. What would be evidence against it is the absence of the struggle — the person in whom nothing has been disturbed at all.

The test, then, is not *have you had a powerful experience?* but *has something in you been permanently altered?* Not: were you moved on that occasion. But: do you want different things than you did, and has it lasted?

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask the second sign's question directly: is your joy chiefly that God is glorious, or chiefly that you are safe?
2. Watch how you speak of other Christians who differ from you. Zeal that turns harsh has failed the eighth sign.
3. Look for lopsidedness. Where is your religion strong in public and absent in private?
4. Test your appetite. Has receiving from God made you hungrier or more satisfied with your present state?
5. Do not audit yourself daily. Review honestly, then turn your eyes to Christ, where assurance actually rests.

A PRAYER

Lord, search me, but do not leave me examining myself for ever.

Show me whether I love You for what You are or only for what You give. Show me whether my zeal has turned bitter. Show me the corner of my life where I have allowed grace no entry.

Give me the lowliness that comes from seeing You rather than the self-pity that comes from seeing myself.

And make me hungrier. Whatever You have given me, let it leave me wanting more of You. Amen.

Christian Practice

Ye shall know them by their fruits.

MATTHEW 7:16

The twelfth and last sign in *Religious Affections* occupies more space than several of the others together, and Edwards left no doubt about its standing. Christian practice — how a person actually lives — is the chief evidence of grace, both to observers and to the believer himself.

This is the conclusion of his life's work on the question, and it is the most practically important thing he ever wrote.

Above every experience

The claim is stronger than we might expect from the theologian of the affections, and that is precisely what makes it significant.

Edwards had spent his career defending the necessity of inward experience against those who wanted religion reduced to conduct. And having done so, he concluded that when it comes to *evidence*, conduct outranks experience — including our own memory of our own experiences.

His reasoning is straightforward. An experience is a single event, remembered by a mind we already know to be self-deceiving, uncheckable by anyone else, and frequently improved in the retelling. A life is a long series of choices under varied pressure, visible to others, and very difficult to counterfeit for decades.

He that saith, I know him, and keepeth not his commandments, is a liar, and the truth is not in him.

1 JOHN 2:4

If ye love me, keep my commandments.

JOHN 14:15

This carries a hard implication which Edwards did not soften. A person whose sole ground of assurance is a conversion experience years ago, unsupported by any subsequent alteration in how he lives, has weaker evidence than he supposes. The experience may have been genuine. But it is not the evidence he thinks it is.

Three qualities of the practice that counts

Not all obedience is evidence, and Edwards specified what kind is.

It must be **universal**. The believer does not select which commands suit him. Partial obedience is the signature of self-will, since a man who keeps the rules he agrees with is following himself. Edwards noted that we are most revealed by the command we quietly exempt ourselves from.

It must be **constant** — maintained under pressure, not merely when convenient. Trial is the test, because trial is where motives are exposed. A religion that survives only in good weather has not been tested at all.

And it must be **persevering**, continuing to the end of life. Edwards gave great weight to endurance, and it is one of the reasons he wrote after the awakening rather than during it. Anyone can be fervent in a season when everyone around them is fervent. What a movement produces ten years later is the measure of it.

But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved.

MATTHEW 24:13

Not works-righteousness

It is essential to see why this is not a retreat from the doctrine of chapter nine.

Edwards is not saying that practice justifies. He is saying that practice *evidences*. Justification is by faith alone, apart from works, received complete at the moment of believing. The question here is a different one entirely: how does anyone — including you — know whether that faith is present?

The answer Scripture gives is fruit. Fruit does not grow the tree; it shows what the tree is.

Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone.

JAMES 2:17

Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven.

MATTHEW 7:21

Edwards was careful to add that Christian practice does not mean sinless practice, and the qualification matters for the tender conscience.

What is in view is the direction and the general course of a life, not the absence of failure. The believer sins, and repents, and returns. The pattern is one of continuing return. What is inconsistent with grace is not falling but settling — the comfortable arrangement in which a person maintains a religious identity alongside a sin he has no intention of leaving.

The question is not *have you failed?* It is *which direction are you facing when you get up?*

The evidence nobody sees

Edwards laid particular weight on a part of Christian practice that no congregation can observe: what a believer does when he is entirely alone.

His reasoning is simple. Public religion has an audience, and an audience is a motive. A man may pray well in a meeting, give generously where giving is noticed, and speak warmly of Christ in company, for reasons that have nothing to do with Christ. Remove the observers, and the motive is exposed.

But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.

MATTHEW 6:6

The Lord's instruction, Edwards noted, is not merely about avoiding hypocrisy. It is about establishing a region of a person's life in which the only possible audience is God — and therefore the only possible motive is God.

He applied the same test to a range of hidden things. What occupies the mind when it is not directed at a task. What a person does with an unexpected free hour. How he behaves towards those who can do nothing for him and cannot damage him. What he thinks about while pretending to listen. Whether he gives when no record is kept.

But when thou doest alms, let not thy left hand know what thy right hand doeth.

MATTHEW 6:3

There is a searching corollary. If a believer's secret life is empty — no private prayer, no reading that nobody knows about, no giving that goes unrecorded — then his religion consists entirely of the parts that are seen. That is not proof of anything, since seasons of dryness are real and common. But it is a question worth asking, and asking honestly, because the answer is available to no one else.

Edwards himself is a useful case. He rose very early, spent long hours in the study, prayed while riding alone through the woods, and pinned scraps of paper to his coat to record thoughts on those rides. Almost none of that was visible to his congregation, and there was nothing to be gained from it socially. It is the best evidence we have about the man, precisely because it had no audience.

The question is not what your church sees. It is what happens in the hours nobody records.

1. Ask what your life would suggest about your faith to someone who could observe it for a year without hearing you speak.
2. Find the command you have quietly exempted yourself from. Everyone has one. Name it.
3. Test constancy: does your obedience hold under pressure, or only when it costs little?
4. If your assurance rests entirely on a past experience, do not discard it — but ask what has happened since.
5. Distinguish falling from settling. Identify anything you have stopped intending to leave, and stop making peace with it.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You said that we would be known by our fruit, and I would rather be known by my beliefs, or by an experience I once had.

Show me the command I have excused myself from. Show me where my obedience is selective, and where it holds only while it is easy.

I do not ask to be spared failure — I ask that I would always be found turning back. Keep me from settling anywhere You have told me not to stay.

Make my life the evidence, and not merely my words. Amen.

True Virtue

For if ye love them which love you, what reward have ye? do not even the publicans the same?

MATTHEW 5:46

Among the works Edwards wrote at Stockbridge and never saw published was a short, dense dissertation called *The Nature of True Virtue*. It asks what genuine goodness actually is, and its answer exposes a great deal of respectable morality as something other than virtue.

Benevolence to being in general

Edwards's definition is that true virtue consists most essentially in benevolence to Being in general — a settled goodwill towards all that exists, proportioned to its worth, and therefore directed first and supremely to God, who is the greatest and best of all beings.

That sounds abstract until you see what it excludes.

Consider a man who loves his family devotedly, is loyal to his friends, serves his town, and would die for his country. We would call him a good man, and in an important sense he is. But Edwards asks a searching question: what is the boundary of his goodwill, and why is it drawn there?

If it extends to his own circle and stops, then it may be nothing more than self-love enlarged. The family is *his* family; the country is *his* country. What appears as generosity may be attachment to an extension of himself. Edwards called these private systems — limited communities of affection which look like virtue from inside and function as selfishness from outside.

And if ye do good to them which do good to you, what thank have ye? for sinners also do even the same.

LUKE 6:33

The Lord's argument is exactly Edwards's. Loving those who love you proves nothing, because it is available to anyone and requires no grace at all.

Why it must begin with God

The reason true virtue must be directed first to God is not arbitrary.

If goodwill is to be proportioned to worth, and God is infinitely worthy, then a virtue that leaves God out has failed at the most important point. It has allocated love carefully among lesser beings while ignoring

the greatest. A man may be scrupulously fair to his neighbours and profoundly unjust to his Maker.

Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart ...this is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.

MATTHEW 22:37–39

Note the order, and note that the second is *like* the first — flowing from it, sharing its nature. Love for God, rightly held, necessarily enlarges the circle of love for others, because it reorients the whole self away from its own centre.

If a man say, I love God, and hateth his brother, he is a liar: for he that loveth not his brother whom he hath seen, how can he love God whom he hath not seen?

1 JOHN 4:20

The doctrine that convicted its author

There is a painful and instructive postscript to this chapter, and it would be dishonest to omit it.

Edwards wrote this dissertation while owning human beings.

His own principle — that virtue must extend beyond every private system, that goodwill limited to one's own circle is self-love wearing a respectable face — is precisely the argument that condemns slaveholding. He did not apply it. He drew the boundary of his benevolence around a community that excluded the people working in his house, and did not notice.

Within one generation his students did notice. Samuel Hopkins and Edwards's own son became prominent opponents of slavery, and they argued their case directly from this doctrine, maintaining that they were simply following their teacher's logic to its proper end. They were right.

This is worth sitting with, because it demonstrates something Edwards himself taught more forcefully than anyone: that a man may hold a true principle, teach it brilliantly, and remain blind to its application in the one place where it would cost him. The heart is deceitful above all things, and it is most deceitful where we most benefit.

None of which makes the principle false. It makes it dangerous — which is what true principles generally are.

So the question this chapter puts is simple and inescapable.

Where is the boundary of your goodwill? Not what you profess, but where your actual care runs out — which people fall outside it, and what advantage you gain from the line being drawn where it is.

Common virtue is still a good

Edwards took care to prevent a misreading that his argument invites, and the qualification matters greatly for how Christians regard the world around them.

To say that natural affection is not true virtue is not to say it is worthless.

Edwards held that the natural loves — of parents for children, of friends for one another, of citizens for their community — together with natural conscience, the sense of justice, pity for suffering and shame at cruelty, are real goods. They are God's gifts, given to fallen people, and they restrain the world from being as bad as it could be. Without them human society would be unliveable.

For when the Gentiles, which have not the law, do by nature the things contained in the law ...shew the work of the law written in their hearts.

ROMANS 2:14–15

So the Christian is not to sneer at the decency of unbelievers, nor to pretend that the kind atheist is secretly a monster, nor to treat every virtue outside the church as hypocrisy. That posture is both false and repellent, and it has done enormous damage to the credibility of the gospel.

What Edwards insisted upon is a narrower and more precise point: these goods, real as they are, do not amount to the thing God requires, because they leave the centre unchanged. A man may be admirable in every direction except the one that matters most, and be, at the root, still living for himself.

The distinction is between what is genuinely good and what is savingly good. Common virtue restrains; it does not reconcile.

For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: not of works, lest any man should boast.

EPHESIANS 2:8–9

There is a practical use in holding this properly. It should make Christians generous in their assessment of others and severe in the assessment of themselves — able to recognise and praise goodness wherever it appears, while refusing to rest their own hope on any quantity of it.

And it removes a common evangelistic error. The task is not to persuade decent people that they are secretly wicked. It is to show them that a life organised around any centre but God, however admirable its conduct, has missed the point of being alive.

1. Map the boundary of your practical benevolence. Who is inside it? Who is outside, and why?
2. Ask what you gain from that boundary being where it is. That question does most of the work.
3. Identify one group you find it easy to disregard. Do something concrete for one of them this month.
4. Test whether your love for family, church or nation is virtue or enlarged self-interest. Would it survive if they ceased to be yours?
5. Ask God to show you the application of a truth you hold that you have never allowed to cost you anything.

A PRAYER

Father, You are the greatest of all beings, and true goodness begins with loving You above everything.

I have drawn a circle around the people who are mine, and I have called my loyalty to them virtue. Show me where my goodwill stops, and why it stops there.

I know that I am most blind where I most benefit. Teach me to suspect myself exactly at the point where a truth would cost me something.

Enlarge my heart. Let me love what You love, without the boundary I have quietly drawn. Amen.

Heaven is a World of Love

*Charity never faileth: but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail;
whether there be tongues, they shall cease.*

1 CORINTHIANS 13:8

In 1738 Edwards preached a series through 1 Corinthians 13, published long afterwards as *Charity and Its Fruits*. The final sermon is called *Heaven is a World of Love*, and anyone who believes Edwards was a gloomy man should be required to read it before saying so again.

It is the most tender thing he wrote, and it is the natural conclusion of everything else in this book.

The fountain and the stream

His governing image is a river.

God, he said, is the fountain of love, as the sun is the fountain of light. In heaven that love is not rationed or interrupted; it pours out from God, fills every inhabitant, and flows back to Him in adoration and outward to one another in delight. The whole society is one circulation of love, and nothing obstructs it anywhere.

God is love; and he that dwelleth in love dwelleth in God, and God in him.

1 JOHN 4:16

Edwards observed that on earth love is real but always impeded. We love, and we are misunderstood. We love, and we are jealous. We love, and the person dies. We love, and our own coldness returns. Every affection here is mixed with something that spoils it.

In heaven every obstruction is gone. Love has perfect objects, perfect capacity to receive, perfect freedom of expression, perfect security, and endless duration. Nothing is withheld and nothing is lost.

And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain: for the former things are passed away.

REVELATION 21:4

Differences without envy

Edwards addressed a question that troubles many people, and his answer is one of the loveliest passages in his work.

Scripture indicates that there will be differences in heaven — degrees of glory, varying capacities, some given more than others. Does that not introduce comparison, and with it the possibility of envy?

His answer is that envy is impossible there, because envy requires a self at the centre. Where love is perfect, each person's joy in another's greater glory is itself a source of happiness. The one with the smaller vessel is not diminished by the larger; he delights in it. And the one with the greater capacity does not look down but pours out.

Every vessel is full. That is the point. A smaller cup filled to the brim is not less full than a larger one, and in a society without self-regard, the size of one's neighbour's cup is a matter of pure gladness.

What this does for now

Edwards did not treat heaven as a consolation to be produced at funerals. He treated it as a description of the direction in which the Christian life is already moving.

If heaven is a world of love, then love is not an optional refinement of Christian character; it is the substance of the thing we are being prepared for. A person being fitted for that world is being made loving now, and a person growing harder is moving the wrong way whatever else is true of him.

This is why the sermon sits where it does, at the end of a series on 1 Corinthians 13. Paul's argument is that gifts pass away and love remains — which means that love is the only part of our present Christian experience that carries over unchanged.

And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

Faith will become sight. Hope will become possession. Love simply continues, and grows.

There is a striking implication for how we think about our own deaths, and Edwards drew it out.

For the believer, dying is not principally leaving. It is arriving in the society for which he has been in training, among people he will love perfectly and be loved by perfectly, in the presence of the Fountain.

Father, I will that they also, whom thou hast given me, be with me where I am; that they may behold my glory.

JOHN 17:24

That is the last prayer of Christ for His people, and it is the whole of heaven in a sentence.

Heaven begun below

Edwards did not regard heaven as merely future. He held that the same love which fills that world is already at work in this one, in the church,

in smaller measure and under difficulty — and that Christian fellowship is the outpost of the world to come.

No man hath seen God at any time. If we love one another, God dwelleth in us, and his love is perfected in us.

1 JOHN 4:12

That is a remarkable claim, and Edwards took it at full weight. The invisible God becomes visible in the mutual love of His people. A congregation in which believers genuinely love one another is not merely a pleasant social arrangement; it is a demonstration of God to a world that cannot see Him directly.

By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another.

JOHN 13:35

This gives the ordinary business of church life a dignity it is rarely accorded. Bearing with a difficult brother, forgiving an old injury, refusing to repeat a piece of gossip, welcoming someone who brings nothing useful — these are not minor housekeeping matters. They are rehearsals, and they are evidence.

Edwards drew a sober conclusion from this, and it should be stated plainly. A person who has no appetite for the company of God's people, who finds their society tedious and their concerns trivial, has reason to examine what he imagines heaven will be. Heaven is not a private arrangement between the individual and God. It is a society, and its whole life is love.

We know that we have passed from death unto life, because we love the brethren.

1 JOHN 3:14

He was equally clear about the direction of the traffic. Our love for one another is not something we generate in order to qualify; it is the overflow of a love received.

We love him, because he first loved us.

1 JOHN 4:19

Which means the remedy for a cold heart towards other Christians is not chiefly to try harder with them. It is to go back to the fountain. A person who has been freshly warmed by the love of God will generally find his patience with his brethren has improved without his having worked directly on it at all.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Test whether your idea of heaven is chiefly relief from trouble or union with God. The difference reveals what you actually want.

2. Where you are envious of another believer's gifting, treat it as practice for a world where such envy will be impossible. Begin rejoicing now.
3. Ask whether you are becoming a more loving person year by year. If not, you are not being prepared for the place you say you are going.
4. Name one relationship where love is currently obstructed by something you control. Remove the obstruction.
5. Read 1 Corinthians 13 as a description of heaven rather than a wedding reading, and notice how it changes.

A PRAYER

Father, You are the fountain of love, and every love I have known here has been a stream running through broken ground.

Thank You that there is a world where nothing obstructs it — no jealousy, no misunderstanding, no coldness, no parting.

Prepare me for it. Make me a person who could be happy there: glad at another's greater glory, free of the self that spoils everything.

And when my turn comes to go, let it not feel like leaving, but like arriving. Amen.

The Resolutions

See then that ye walk circumspectly, not as fools, but as wise, redeeming the time, because the days are evil.

EPHESIANS 5:15–16

Between 1722 and 1723, in his late teens and early twenties, Edwards drew up seventy resolutions governing how he intended to live. He kept them beside him and read them over once a week for years.

They are among the most quoted and most misunderstood documents in his corpus.

The preface everyone skips

Before the first resolution, Edwards wrote a short preamble which changes the meaning of everything that follows, and which is almost always omitted when the list is reproduced.

He states that he is unable to do anything without God's help, and asks God by His grace to enable him to keep these resolutions, so far as they are agreeable to God's will.

Read the list without that, and it is a young man's programme of self-improvement by willpower — and an oppressive one. Read it with the preamble, and it is something else entirely: a set of intentions laid before God by someone who has already conceded he cannot execute them.

The distinction is exactly the one Edwards would spend his life defending. The resolutions do not produce grace. They are how a man who has received grace proposes to spend his time.

What he resolved

The themes recur, and they are worth listing because they show what a God-centred life looked like to him in practice.

Time. He resolved never to lose one moment of time but to use it in the most profitable way he could. The urgency about time never left him, and it is connected to his view of eternity: a short life, an endless consequence.

So teach us to number our days, that we may apply our hearts unto wisdom.

PSALM 90:12

Intensity. He resolved to live with all his might while he lived. Not to drift, not to coast, not to spend a life half-engaged.

The perspective of death. Several resolutions turn on a single device: to act now as he would wish he had acted when he came to die. He resolved never to do anything he would be afraid to do in the last hour of his life. It is a remarkably clarifying test, and it can be applied immediately by anyone.

Go to now, ye that say, To day or to morrow we will go into such a city ...Whereas ye know not what shall be on the morrow. For what is your life? It is even a vapour.

JAMES 4:13–14

Scripture. He resolved to study the Scriptures steadily, constantly and frequently, so as to grow plainly in knowledge of them.

The ordinary. A striking number concern eating, drinking, sleep, speech and temper — the unglamorous machinery of a life. He resolved to guard what he said about others, to examine why he was angry, to be moderate at table. He evidently understood that a life is lost in small increments.

The danger, honestly stated

The *Diary* he kept alongside these records a good deal of discouragement. He falls short repeatedly. He is dissatisfied with himself. There are stretches of spiritual dullness that he notes with distress.

This should be said plainly, because the Resolutions have done harm to scrupulous readers. A person already inclined to perfectionism can take up this list and construct from it a machine for self-condemnation, in which every review produces fresh evidence of failure and the whole exercise drives him further from the God it was meant to serve.

That is not what they are for, and Edwards's own preamble refutes it. The resolutions are aspirations held before a God who is already reconciled, by a man who has already stated he cannot keep them unaided. Anyone who cannot hold them that way should leave them alone.

The enduring value of the practice, stripped of its dangers, is that Edwards made his intentions specific and reviewed them.

Most of us have vague desires to be more disciplined, more prayerful, more generous, and vague desires accomplish nothing because they can never be checked. Edwards wrote his down, in concrete terms, and looked at them weekly.

You do not need seventy. You might manage three.

The ordinary machinery

It is worth setting out how Edwards actually spent his days, because the Resolutions can give the impression of a man sustained by heroic acts of will, and the reality was far more ordinary and far more imitable.

He rose very early — often between four and five — and worked in his study for many hours, by some accounts as many as thirteen a day. He read with a pen in his hand, and filled notebooks continuously: the *Miscellanies*, in which he worked out theological problems over decades; notebooks on Scripture; the *Images of Divine Things*. Paper was scarce and expensive, and he used both sides of everything, including, on one occasion, the receipt for a slave he had purchased.

He rode alone on horseback for exercise and for thinking. When an idea came, he would pin a small scrap of paper to his coat to fix the thought, and returned home some days with his coat conspicuously fluttering. In the evening he read to his family and prayed with them.

Sarah managed a household of thirteen and a stream of visitors, and by every account made the study hours possible. It should also be said plainly that the labour of enslaved people in that household made them possible too.

Whatsoever thy hand findeth to do, do it with thy might.

ECCLESIASTES 9:10

What is instructive here is how unremarkable the components are. Early rising. Long hours. Writing things down. Regular exercise. Reading with attention. Family worship. Reviewing his intentions weekly. None of it requires genius, and the genius he did possess would have produced far less without it.

Edwards's output — roughly twelve hundred surviving sermons, the treatises, the notebooks, the correspondence — was not the product of inspiration arriving. It was the product of a man being at his desk.

Seest thou a man diligent in his business? he shall stand before kings.

PROVERBS 22:29

There is encouragement in this for people of ordinary ability. Most of what lasts is produced by unremarkable people doing unremarkable things for an unreasonable length of time. The resolutions matter less than the habit of returning to them.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Write three resolutions — specific enough to be checked — and set a weekly time to review them.
2. Begin, as Edwards did, by admitting to God that you cannot keep them, and asking for grace. Without that preface the exercise is dangerous.
3. Apply his test to one decision this week: would you do this in the last hour of your life?

4. Audit one day honestly. Where did the hours actually go?
5. If you are prone to scrupulosity, use these gently or not at all. The list is a servant, and it makes a cruel master.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have wanted to be a different sort of person for years without ever saying concretely what I meant, and so nothing has changed.

I am unable to do anything without Your help. I confess that before I resolve anything, so that my resolving does not become another way of trusting myself.

Teach me to number my days. Let me live with all my might while I live, and let me not do today what I would regret in my last hour.

And when I fail, keep me from despair. My standing with You was never built on my consistency. Amen.

A Humble Attempt

*Yea, many people and strong nations shall come to seek the Lord of hosts
in Jerusalem, and to pray before the Lord.*

ZECHARIAH 8:22

The last of Edwards's teachings to consider is the one with the longest reach, and it began as a proposal from Scotland.

In 1744 a group of Scottish ministers agreed to set aside regular times to pray together for the revival of religion and the spread of the gospel, and invited others to join. Edwards took up the idea and in 1747 published a book to promote it, with a title as long as its argument was simple: *An Humble Attempt to Promote Explicit Agreement and Visible Union of God's People in Extraordinary Prayer for the Revival of Religion and the Advancement of Christ's Kingdom on Earth*.

The concert of prayer

The proposal itself was modest. Christians in different places and different denominations would agree to pray at the same appointed times — a quarterly day, and part of each week — for the same object: that God would pour out His Spirit and advance the gospel through the whole earth.

Edwards's argument for it rested on three things.

Scripture promises a great advance. He took texts like Zechariah 8 and Isaiah's visions of the nations streaming in as descriptions of something God actually intends to do in history, not merely poetry.

For the earth shall be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea.

HABAKKUK 2:14

Scripture commands us to ask for it, persistently and without discouragement. He leaned on the parable of the importunate widow, and on Isaiah's watchmen who are told to give God no rest until He establishes His purpose.

Ye that make mention of the Lord, keep not silence, and give him no rest, till he establish, and till he make Jerusalem a praise in the earth.

ISAIAH 62:6–7

And union in prayer has a particular promise attached to it.

If two of you shall agree on earth as touching any thing that they shall ask, it shall be done for them of my Father which is in heaven.

Where the timetable was wrong

Honesty requires a note, because Edwards attached to this book a good deal of speculation about prophetic chronology — attempts to locate the present moment in the scheme of Revelation and to estimate how near the promised outpouring might be.

He was mistaken, as everyone who has attempted such calculations has been mistaken, and the sections of the book devoted to them are the least valuable. It is worth noting that his own Master declined to supply this information (Acts 1:7), and that no one since has improved on that silence.

Take the burden and leave the arithmetic. The command to pray persistently for the advance of the gospel does not depend on knowing when the answer arrives.

What it produced

The postscript to this book is remarkable, and Edwards did not live to see any of it.

An Humble Attempt was read a generation later by a group of Baptist ministers in Northamptonshire, who in 1784 issued a call to united monthly prayer for the conversion of the nations. Among those who took it up was a young cobbler named William Carey. Carey went to India in 1793, and the modern Protestant missionary movement is usually dated from there.

A book about prayer, written by a dismissed pastor on a frontier settlement, helped set in motion the largest missionary expansion in Christian history — after its author was dead.

This is the right place to end, because it gathers everything.

Edwards began with the glory of God as the end for which the world was made. He spent his life on how that glory is seen, loved and lived. And he finished by asking Christians to pray, together and persistently, that the knowledge of that glory would fill the earth.

He never saw the answer. He was dismissed by his congregation, exiled to the frontier, and died at fifty-four after five weeks in a post he had not wanted. By any ordinary measure his career ended in failure.

The knowledge of the glory of the Lord is still spreading. He asked for that, and he is not here to see it, and it is happening anyway.

That is generally how it works.

Be ye steadfast, unmoveable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord.

One work, from beginning to end

Behind Edwards's confidence in prayer lay a particular way of reading history, which he set out in a series of sermons preached at Northampton in 1739 and published afterwards as *A History of the Work of Redemption*.

His thesis was that everything which has happened since the fall — every empire, every war, every migration, every obscure life — belongs to a single project, which is the redemption of a people for God through Christ. History is not a sequence of unrelated events with a religious thread running through part of it. The redemption is the plot, and everything else is the setting.

That in the dispensation of the fulness of times he might gather together in one all things in Christ, both which are in heaven, and which are on earth.

EPHESIANS 1:10

He traced the work from the promise in Eden, through the flood, the calling of Abraham, the exodus, the monarchy, the exile, the prophets, to the incarnation — which he treated as the centre of the whole — and then onward through the spread of the gospel, to a consummation still ahead.

The practical effect of reading history this way is considerable, and it is why this chapter belongs at the end of the book.

It means that no faithful labour is isolated. The believer teaching six children in a village, the translator working through a difficult language, the congregation praying for a country closed to the gospel — each is contributing to a work that has been running for millennia and will certainly be completed. He is not starting something; he is joining something.

Being confident of this very thing, that he which hath begun a good work in you will perform it until the day of Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 1:6

It also supplies patience. Edwards's own vantage point was a frontier village of a few hundred people, in a colony on the edge of the known world, at a moment when the gospel had reached a fraction of the earth. From there he wrote confidently about the knowledge of God filling the whole earth — not because the evidence around him warranted it, but because he had read what God said He would do.

So shall my word be that goeth forth out of my mouth: it shall not return unto me void, but it shall accomplish that which I please.

ISAIAH 55:11

That is the ground of the concert of prayer. We are not asking God to attempt something. We are asking Him to hasten what He has already undertaken.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Join or begin a regular gathering whose explicit purpose is praying for revival and the spread of the gospel. Set a time and keep it.
2. Pray with believers outside your own tradition. Edwards's proposal was deliberately across denominational lines.
3. Ask for something so large that you will not see it answered in your lifetime. Then keep asking.
4. Stop calculating timetables. Spend the energy on intercession instead.
5. Consider that the most fruitful thing you ever do may bear fruit after you are gone, and that you will probably not know. Work anyway.

A PRAYER

Lord of hosts, You have promised that the earth will be filled with the knowledge of Your glory as the waters cover the sea, and I have prayed as though You promised nothing of the kind.

Forgive the smallness of my asking.

Unite Your people in prayer across every line we have drawn between ourselves. Pour out Your Spirit. Advance Your kingdom in places I will never see, among people I will never meet.

I may not live to see the answer. Let me ask for it anyway, and labour, knowing that in You no labour is wasted. Amen.

Conclusion

*But we all, with open face beholding as in a glass the glory of the Lord,
are changed into the same image from glory to glory.*

2 CORINTHIANS 3:18

Eighteen chapters can give the impression that Jonathan Edwards taught many things. He taught one thing, and everything else in him is an application of it.

The one thing is this: *God is infinitely glorious, the human problem is that we cannot see it, and salvation is God giving us eyes.*

Follow the chain and the whole system appears. God created the world for the display and communication of His glory. Human beings were made to see it, love it and reflect it. In the fall the capacity was lost — not the eyes but the taste, so that we look at what is supremely beautiful and feel nothing. That is why the will is bound: not because we are prevented, but because we do not want. Regeneration is the giving of a new spiritual sense, by which the same truths we always knew become suddenly lovely. From that new perception the affections move, and from the affections the whole life follows. And the end of the process is a world of love, where the seeing is unobstructed for ever.

Justification, revival, the affections, true virtue, prayer — each is that one argument applied at a different point.

The danger of this book

If you have read this far, you are in a position of some hazard, and Edwards would have said so first.

The peculiar risk of his theology is that it can be received as a system. It is a magnificent system, and a person can become an enthusiast for it — can learn to talk about the sense of the heart, the beauty of holiness, gracious affections — while remaining exactly the man he was, only better read.

Edwards anticipated this precisely. It is why the final sign in *Religious Affections* is not an inward experience but Christian practice, and why he ranked it above everything a person might feel or remember. He knew that theological sophistication is one of the more effective disguises available to an unconverted heart.

But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves.

JAMES 1:22

So the plainest counsel this book can give is the same as before. Return to the chapter that made you least comfortable — not the one you found most interesting. Take its application points and work through them slowly over months. Then take the next.

What to carry away

Two things, if nothing else.

First, ask for light. This is the request Edwards's whole theology drives towards, and it is the one most of us never make. We ask God for help, for guidance, for provision, for comfort. We rarely ask Him to make us see that He is beautiful — which is the only request that changes anything at the root. You cannot argue yourself into loving God. You can ask.

Open thou mine eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of thy law.

PSALM 119:18

Second, watch your loves rather than your opinions. Edwards's most useful gift to ordinary Christians is the shift of the diagnostic question from *what do you believe?* to *what do you delight in?* The second is far harder to answer dishonestly, and it is the truer map.

A last word about the man

We have been honest in these pages about his failures. He owned human beings while writing that virtue must extend beyond every private circle. He speculated about prophetic chronology and was wrong. He handled the crisis at Northampton in ways that cost him his ministry, and not all the fault lay with his congregation. He could be severe, and his severity did damage that his defenders have sometimes been too quick to explain away.

None of that has been raised to diminish him. It has been raised because he, more than almost anyone, taught that the heart is deceitful beyond our capacity to detect, and that we are blindest where we most benefit. His life is the demonstration of his own doctrine. It would be a strange tribute to pretend otherwise.

And there is this, which is the most hopeful thing in his whole story. The principle he failed to apply was applied by those who came after him, using his own arguments, against his own practice. The truth he taught outlived and overruled the man who taught it.

That is what happens to true things. They do not depend on the vessel.

But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:7

Edwards died at fifty-four, five weeks into a job he had not wanted, in a town he barely knew, eight years after being dismissed by the congregation he had served for twenty-three. He was conscious near the end, and what he said to those around the bed was that they should trust in God, and then they need not fear.

It is a small sentence for so large a mind. It is also, on his own principles, the only conclusion there was.

A PRAYER

Father, I have read about Your glory and I am not sure I have seen it.

I can describe the beauty of holiness and remain unmoved by it. I can explain the sense of the heart and not possess it. Do not let me settle for a theology of light without the light.

Open my eyes. Change what I love. And let the change show, not in what I can say, but in how I live when no one is watching.

You are glorious. Make me see it, and make me glad. Amen.

A Reader's Guide to Jonathan Edwards

*Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not
to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.*

2 TIMOTHY 2:15

Edwards is easier to obtain than almost any other major theologian and harder than most to read. Everything he wrote is out of copyright, and the complete Yale edition — twenty-six printed volumes, with a great deal more unpublished material — is available without charge from the Jonathan Edwards Center at Yale University. There is no financial barrier to reading him at all.

The barrier is his prose. He wrote long, carefully qualified sentences for readers with more patience than we have. The remedy is to begin with the sermons, which were written to be heard, and to leave the treatises until the voice is familiar.

Begin here

A Divine and Supernatural Light (1734). Short, and the key to everything else. If you read one thing, read this.

The Excellency of Christ. On the Lion and the Lamb. The most beautiful of his sermons and the most immediately accessible.

Heaven is a World of Love, the closing sermon of *Charity and Its Fruits* (1738). The best correction to his reputation.

Personal Narrative and the *Resolutions*. Brief autobiographical pieces, invaluable for seeing the man behind the arguments.

The central work

A Treatise Concerning Religious Affections (1746). His masterpiece and the basis of chapters eleven to fourteen of this book. It is long and demanding. Several reliable abridgements exist and there is no shame whatever in starting with one; the twelve signs in Part III are the heart of it and can be read on their own.

The major treatises

Freedom of the Will (1754). The most philosophically formidable thing he wrote, and hard going. Read a summary first.

The Great Christian Doctrine of Original Sin Defended (1758).

The End for Which God Created the World and *The Nature of True Virtue*, published together after his death as *Two Dissertations* (1765).

Short, dense, and the foundation of chapters one and fifteen.

On revival

A Faithful Narrative of the Surprising Work of God (1737). His account of the Northampton awakening; the book that made him internationally known.

The Distinguishing Marks of a Work of the Spirit of God (1741). Brief and immediately useful for anyone assessing a movement today.

Some Thoughts Concerning the Present Revival (1742).

An Humble Attempt (1747). On united prayer. Skip the chronological speculation and keep the argument.

Also worth knowing

The Life of David Brainerd (1749). Edwards's edition of the journals of the young missionary who died in his house. It became one of the most influential missionary books ever published, read by Carey, Martyn and Hudson Taylor. Read it aware that Brainerd's relentless self-examination has harmed some readers as much as it has inspired others.

A History of the Work of Redemption. Sermons tracing God's single redemptive purpose through all of history.

About Edwards

George Marsden's *Jonathan Edwards: A Life* (2003) is the standard modern biography and is outstanding — thorough, sympathetic and candid about the failures. Iain Murray's *Jonathan Edwards: A New Biography* (1987) is warmer and more devotional, and less searching on the difficult matters. On slavery, the essential scholarship is by Kenneth Minkema, whose work brought the documentary evidence to light.

Read more than one. No single account of him is disinterested.

Three counsels for reading him

Read him with the Bible open. His authority is entirely borrowed, and he would have been the first to insist that anything of his which cannot be sustained from Scripture should be discarded.

Read him for the burden rather than the system. Where he presses a framework beyond what Scripture states — and in *Freedom of the Will*, in the mechanism of original sin, in the prophetic timetables, he does — take the pastoral concern and leave the scaffolding.

Read him slowly, and aloud if the sentences resist. These are not books to be finished. A page a day, prayed over, will do more than a volume a week admired.

Prove all things; hold fast that which is good.

